

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Every journey begins with leaving home.
The most important one ends by creating it.



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The White Envelope

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Dedication

For my father,
whose faith in me began long before mine did.

Thirukkural

குறள்

உள்ளியது எய்தல் எளிதுமன் மற்றுந்தான்
உள்ளியது உள்ளப் பெறின்.

What one has firmly resolved is easy to attain,
if the mind remains steadfast upon that purpose.

— திருவள்ளுவர் (Thiruvalluvar)

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Prologue

There are some things we carry through life without realizing it.

Among them is a plain white envelope with a few words embossed in gold and an address written across the front. For more than twenty-five years, it has remained quietly tucked inside the leather bag where I keep my certificates and other important papers.

Time has softened its folds. The paper has lost the brightness it once had. Yet every time I come across it, the years quietly disappear.

When I first held that envelope in my hands, I saw only an appointment letter. Like any young engineering graduate, I believed it marked the beginning of a career. I carefully placed it with my certificates, packed my suitcase, and prepared to leave home for the first time.

I never imagined that, years later, the envelope would still be with me.

The journey that followed changed almost everything.

The envelope remained exactly where I had first placed it.

This is where the story begins.

Part I — Leaving Home

Chapter 1 - The Departure

The White Envelope

There are moments in life that announce themselves with great fanfare.

Others arrive quietly, disguised as an ordinary afternoon.

Mine arrived in a large white envelope.

I had completed my engineering in Computer Science and, like many fresh graduates of that time, was waiting for my first opportunity. I wasn't someone who had drawn a detailed map of my future. I wasn't counting promotions that hadn't happened or dreaming about where I wanted to be ten years later. I simply hoped that somewhere, someone would give me my first chance.

My father, however, had always been far more certain about my future than I was.

He had dreamed of seeing me enter IIT. My marks had other plans. I remember feeling that I had disappointed him. But strangely, he never behaved as though I had. His confidence never wavered.

"You'll do well," he would say with a certainty that puzzled me.

One afternoon, that certainty arrived at our doorstep.

A large white envelope.

The word "Congratulations" was embossed in gold.

I still remember my father asking me to open it quickly. My mother stood beside him, waiting silently. My younger sister hovered nearby, trying to read my face before I had even unfolded the letter.

I had been selected.

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The joy that filled our small home that day is difficult to describe even now.

For me, it meant my first job.

For my father, it meant that years of faith had finally found their answer.

None of us, however, paid much attention to one line further down the letter.

Reporting Location: Heavy Electrical Equipment Plant, BHEL, Ranipur.

It would take us a few more minutes—and an old atlas—to discover just how far from home that single line would take me.

The Suitcase

The suitcase lay open on the floor of my room.

It wasn't particularly large, but somehow it looked big enough to carry an entirely new life.

The first things I packed were my engineering certificates. I checked them more than once, not because I expected them to disappear, but because they represented everything I had worked for over the previous four years. Without them, the journey to BHEL would have felt incomplete.

A few engineering books followed. I wasn't sure whether I would need them immediately, but leaving them behind never felt like an option. Somewhere between the books, I tucked in a handful of Tamil music cassettes. I had no idea what life in North India would be like, but I knew I wanted to carry a little piece of home with me.

The appointment letter was placed carefully inside the suitcase.

THE DEPARTURE

I remember checking once again that it was there before closing the zip.

Beside the suitcase lay a green army-style bedroll. Almost everyone travelling long distances in those days seemed to own one. Rolled tightly, it carried the things that wouldn't fit inside the suitcase and would become my bed for the long journey ahead.

I don't remember much conversation inside the house that evening.

Perhaps there was plenty.

Perhaps there was very little.

Memory is strange that way.

What I remember clearly is that, for the first time in my life, everything I owned that mattered had to fit inside one suitcase and one green bedroll.

Looking back now, I realise I wasn't just packing clothes, books and certificates.

I was packing up the life I had known until then.

When the suitcase was finally closed, I stood looking at it for a few moments.

It didn't seem particularly heavy.

Looking back, I realise it was carrying far more than I understood at the time.

Sometime the following morning, a taxi arrived outside our home.

I don't remember the make of the car or who had arranged it. I only remember the quiet excitement of lifting my suitcase, picking up the green bedroll, and walking towards it while my family followed behind.

None of us said anything extraordinary.

There was no dramatic farewell.
It was simply another morning.
Or at least, that's what it appeared to be.
I placed the suitcase in the boot.
Closed it gently.
And climbed inside.
The journey had begun.

The Train Pulls Away

Tamil Nadu Express left Chennai every night at ten.
Like every evening, Chennai Central was overflowing with people.
Families saying goodbye, vendors weaving through the crowd, porters balancing impossible loads on their heads, announcements echoing across the platforms—it was the familiar chaos of India's busiest railway stations.
Only this time, I wasn't there to receive someone.
I was leaving.
It was my first long-distance journey alone.
We had reached the station well in advance and the train was already waiting patiently at the platform. I carried my suitcase while my father walked beside me. Somewhere behind us were my mother and sister, quietly taking in a moment that none of us fully understood.
I don't remember my coach number anymore.
I don't remember my berth either.
Memory has quietly erased those details.
What it has preserved are the faces.

THE DEPARTURE

My father looked proud.

He had always believed I would do well, long before I believed it myself.

My mother tried to hide her emotions the way only mothers can.

My younger sister looked at everything with excitement and curiosity, almost as if she wished she too could begin an adventure like this one someday.

The whistle finally broke the moment.

The train gave a gentle jerk before slowly beginning to move.

I stood near the window waving.

They waved back.

For a few seconds my parents walked alongside the moving train, trying to keep pace.

Then the train gathered speed.

They slowed down.

The distance between us quietly began to grow.

I kept looking until the familiar faces disappeared into the crowd.

Only then did it truly sink in.

For the first time in my life, I was completely on my own.

It was an unfamiliar feeling.

There was excitement.

There was fear.

And somewhere between the two was a strange sense of freedom.

I had no idea when I would return home again.

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The journey had truly begun.

Chapter 2 - A New World

The First Stop

The train had been moving for a few hours when it stopped at the first station.

I don't remember the name of the station anymore.

What I remember is how different everything suddenly felt.

Until then I had spent most of the journey looking out of the window into the darkness, replaying the evening in my mind. Chennai Central, my parents walking alongside the moving train, my sister waving until I could no longer see her.

For the first time in my life, nobody in that train knew who I was.

It was a strangely liberating feeling.

Somewhere during those first few hours, a thought entered my mind.

If I wanted to smoke a cigarette, nobody would stop me.

Back home, even the thought carried the fear that someone might recognise me and the news would somehow find its way back to my parents. Here, I was just another passenger on a train heading north.

I stepped onto the platform.

Not because I needed anything.

Simply because I could.

A small cigarette stall stood some distance away from my coach. I walked towards it, bought a packet of cigarettes and handed the shopkeeper a hundred-rupee note.

He opened his cash drawer and began counting the change.

Slowly.

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Painfully slowly.

I wasn't paying much attention until I heard the long whistle of the train.

I turned around.

The train had begun to move.

I looked back at the shopkeeper.

He was still counting.

For a brief second I hesitated.

The remaining change...

or the train.

The decision took less than a heartbeat.

I left the money behind and ran.

I had stepped onto the platform with nothing in my hands, expecting to return in a minute. Now the only thing that mattered was catching the train

For a few moments I simply stood near the doorway, breathing heavily.

The platform slowly slipped away into the darkness.

Looking back today, losing the remaining change was insignificant.

Missing that train would have been unforgettable.

Years later, I smile whenever I think about that little episode.

It was probably the first lesson adulthood taught me.

That night I lost a few rupees.

Looking back, it was a small price to pay for my first lesson in living on my own

Delhi in Winter

It was around seven in the morning when Tamil Nadu Express rolled into New Delhi.

The new millennium had just begun.

So had a completely new chapter of my life.

The first thing that greeted me was not Delhi.

It was the cold.

I had never experienced a North Indian winter before. Coming from Chennai, I had underestimated what January meant in Delhi. I stood on the platform wearing nothing more than a half sweater, watching people wrapped in thick jackets move confidently through the fog.

The railway station was alive.

People rushed towards arriving trains searching for relatives and friends.

Some held flowers.

Some carried blankets.

Some shouted names above the noise of the station.

I stood there with my suitcase and green bedroll.

Nobody was waiting for me.

For a brief moment, I realised that every decision from here onward would be mine.

My journey wasn't over yet.

I had a reservation onward to Haridwar, but finding the connecting train proved far more difficult than I had imagined. My broken Hindi and the sleepy enquiry counters didn't make things any easier.

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After several unsuccessful attempts to understand where I needed to go, I made my first important decision on my own.

I abandoned the train.

If I couldn't find it, I would find another way.

Outside the station I took an auto to the Inter State Bus Terminal at Kashmiri Gate.

I had no map.

No mobile phone.

No one to ask for help except strangers.

Looking back today, it feels like a small decision.

At twenty-three, it felt like navigating an entirely new world.

Little did I know that this would become the first of many moments when I would discover that confidence is rarely something we begin with.

More often, it is something we earn by making one uncertain decision after another.

The Road to Haridwar

Sometimes the best plans are the ones we never follow.

Outside the railway station, Delhi felt larger and noisier than anything I had experienced before. Autos came and went, buses roared past, and people seemed to know exactly where they were going. I did not. Carrying my suitcase, I found an auto-rickshaw and asked to be taken to the Inter State Bus Terminal at Kashmiri Gate. It was the only plan I had left.

I had no mobile phone, no maps and no one waiting to guide me. Every small decision depended entirely on my own judgement. I

remember watching the city through the open side of the auto, wondering if I had made the right choice.

Fortunately, the driver had understood exactly where I wanted to go. The bus terminal was exactly where he had promised it would be.

After finding a bus to Haridwar, I climbed aboard with my suitcase and green bedroll, relieved that at least the next part of the journey was finally underway.

During my engineering days in Trichy, travelling home to Chennai by bus had become a familiar routine. The buses were reasonably comfortable, the roads smooth, and the journey predictable.

Somewhere along the way, I had quietly assumed that travelling across the rest of India would be much the same.

The road to Haridwar corrected that assumption rather quickly.

My seat happened to be in the last row of the bus.

Every bump in the road seemed determined to introduce itself personally. The suspension offered little comfort, and before long I had learnt that sitting in the last row on North Indian roads was a very different experience from anything I had known back home.

Yet, despite the uncomfortable ride, I hardly looked away from the window.

Everything outside fascinated me.

Endless sugarcane fields stretched across the countryside. Tractor trolleys overloaded with freshly harvested cane moved slowly along the roads. Small roadside tea stalls appeared every few kilometres, surrounded by people beginning another ordinary day.

It was a world I had never seen before.

Coming from Tamil Nadu, even the landscape felt different.

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The journey was long, noisy and uncomfortable.

It was also strangely beautiful.

Every passing village reminded me that I was travelling farther away from everything that had once felt familiar.

As the bus finally approached Haridwar, I picked up my suitcase and lifted the green bedroll onto my shoulder.

Until a few days earlier, Haridwar had simply been a name printed on my appointment letter.

Now it stood outside the window.

It was time to begin the next chapter of my life.

Part II - Becoming an Engineer

Chapter 3 - Learning to Belong

First Morning in Haridwar

The first sound I heard in Haridwar wasn't the temple bells.

It was the gentle electronic beep of my Casio watch.

For a few seconds I stared blankly at the unfamiliar ceiling, unsure where I was. The previous three days had merged into one long journey of railway platforms, crowded buses, winter fog and broken sleep. Then memory returned in a rush.

Haridwar.

I smiled.

Yesterday evening I had arrived after nearly forty-eight hours of travel from Chennai, followed by an unforgettable bus ride from Delhi. Too exhausted to search for BHEL at night, I had checked into a modest hotel near the bus stand, convinced I would begin my new life the following morning.

That morning had arrived.

The room was barely large enough for the narrow double bed, a small wooden table and a portable television that I had never bothered to switch on. The thick quilt that had seemed impossibly heavy the previous night now lay folded at the foot of the bed. Outside the small window, winter had wrapped the town in a pale mist. Somewhere in the distance a temple bell rang softly, followed by the faint sound of bicycle bells and auto-rickshaw engines coming to life.

Haridwar was awake.

So was I.

The first luxury I granted myself was something I had taken for granted all my life—a hot bath.

Three days of trains, buses and station waiting rooms leave behind more than tiredness. They leave behind a layer of dust that seems to settle not only on your clothes but on your mind. As the first stream of hot water struck my shoulders, I stood motionless, letting the warmth wash away the fatigue of the journey. The cramped railway compartments, the freezing Delhi morning, the pungent bus ride with the Rajasthani pilgrims, the endless highway to Haridwar—they all seemed to dissolve into the steam.

I finally felt human again.

Dressed in freshly ironed clothes, I carefully repacked my small suitcase. Sitting on top of my clothes was the large white envelope that had changed the course of my life.

Even months later, I still found myself looking at it.

I remembered the afternoon it had arrived at our home in Chennai. The envelope was impossible to ignore—thick, official and embossed with the word Congratulations in both English and Hindi. My parents had gathered around as I opened it. My father tried to appear calm, but I could see the excitement in his eyes. My mother listened quietly while I read every line aloud.

I had been selected as an Engineer Trainee in Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited.

For a young engineering graduate who had spent months searching for work, it felt like the world had finally opened a door.

The celebration, however, lasted only until I reached the posting location.

Heavy Electrical Equipment Plant, Ranipur.

None of us knew where Ranipur was.

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Within minutes I had pulled out our old school atlas and spread it across the floor. This was long before online maps and smartphones. Every journey began with paper maps and imagination. I searched every corner of India until I found Ranipur, tucked away near Haridwar in Uttar Pradesh. Uttarakhand had not yet been carved out as a separate state.

The distance looked enormous.

Nearly two thousand kilometres from home.

That was the first moment I truly realised that accepting a job also meant leaving behind everything familiar.

I folded the joining letter carefully and slipped it back into the envelope.

It had brought me here.

Now it had one more responsibility—to get me through my first day.

After checking out of the hotel, I stepped into the crisp January morning with my suitcase beside me. The streets were already alive. Tea stalls sent thin columns of steam into the cold air. Shopkeepers rolled up their shutters while pilgrims, wrapped in shawls, made their way towards the ghats.

An auto-rickshaw slowed beside me.

“BHEL?” I asked.

The driver nodded.

Then came a question I wasn’t prepared for.

“Kaunsa sector?”

I froze.

Sector?

I had absolutely no idea.

My joining letter simply said HEEP, BHEL, Ranipur. No building number. No department. No hostel. Nothing.

I unfolded the letter once more, hoping I had overlooked something. The driver waited patiently.

Finally, I looked up and said, almost apologetically,

“Main Gate.”

He scratched his head for a moment, shrugged, and motioned for me to get in.

The noisy front-engine auto rattled through the streets of Haridwar before leaving the town behind. The roads widened, and the buildings slowly gave way to a vast industrial township. Workers on bicycles, buses filled with employees, security jeeps and long factory walls began to appear.

Then I saw it.

The main gate.

It was far larger than anything I had imagined.

Beside it stood the administrative building—solid, imposing and purposeful. Streams of employees walked confidently through the gates as though they had been doing it for years.

I climbed out of the auto and stood still for a moment.

Yesterday I had been another traveller dragging a suitcase across railway stations.

Today I was about to enter one of India’s largest engineering organisations.

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The security personnel checked my joining letter and directed me towards the Human Resources department inside the administrative building.

Outside the office stood nearly a dozen young men, each holding the same unmistakable white envelope.

The anxiety on every face looked familiar.

Some spoke confidently in Hindi. Others stood silently, reading their appointment letters once again. We were strangers, yet we all shared the same uncertainty.

A few minutes later my turn came.

The gentleman behind the desk picked up my joining letter, looked at it carefully, then looked at me.

His eyes stopped at the name.

He frowned.

“VTR... kya hai?”

For a moment I didn’t understand the question.

Then it struck me.

In North India, people identified themselves by surnames.

In the South, many of us carried our father’s initials instead.

I smiled.

“It’s my initials,” I replied.

He looked unconvinced.

I took a deep breath.

“Velayudham... Thulasi Raman.”

He repeated each word slowly, nodded with satisfaction and began filling out the paperwork.

It was a tiny conversation.

But standing there in that office, I realised that my journey wasn't just across two thousand kilometres of India.

It was across two very different ways of seeing the same country.

Becoming Engineer Trainees

The paperwork in the Human Resources office took less time than I had expected.

One by one, the white envelopes disappeared into neat stacks on the officers' desks, replaced by forms, signatures and instructions. Every few minutes another name was called, another document verified, another nervous graduate welcomed into the organisation.

When the formalities were complete, one of the officers looked up from his desk.

"All Engineer Trainees will now report to the BHEL Hospital for the medical examination."

That was it.

No orientation.

No speeches.

Just a simple instruction.

A few moments later, nearly a dozen of us stepped out of the administrative building together. Until then we had all been strangers, united only by identical appointment letters and uncertain expressions.

Now we had our first destination as a batch.

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The hospital was said to be within walking distance, so we began making our way through the township.

It was my first real opportunity to observe the world I had just joined.

Wide, tree-lined roads stretched between neatly planned buildings. Employees cycled past us with the ease of people who had followed the same route for years. Company buses rolled quietly towards the factory gates. Children in school uniforms waited at bus stops while women carried shopping bags from the nearby market.

This wasn't merely a factory.

It was a town built around one.

The silence among us lasted only a few minutes before someone finally broke it.

"Hi, I'm Arvind."

He smiled as he adjusted the white envelope tucked under his arm.

Another voice joined in.

"Sandeep."

Then another.

"Karan."

The introductions travelled naturally through the group until someone turned towards me.

"And you?"

"Ravi."

"Where are you from?"

"Chennai."

For a brief second everyone looked at me with genuine curiosity.

“Chennai?”

I nodded.

It turned out I was the only one who had travelled nearly two thousand kilometres to join this batch. Most of the others came from places I had only seen on road signs during yesterday’s bus journey—Meerut, Dehradun, Bareilly, Jodhpur and, to my surprise, even Haridwar itself.

That single answer made introductions easier.

I no longer had to remember every face immediately.

They remembered me.

“The one from Chennai.”

By the time we reached the hospital, the awkwardness had already begun to disappear.

The BHEL Hospital was far larger than I had imagined a company hospital would be. Employees and their families filled the waiting areas, doctors moved briskly between departments and nurses seemed to know exactly where everyone belonged.

Only later would I learn why.

With nearly ten thousand employees and their families living inside the township, BHEL wasn’t supporting a workforce.

It was supporting a small city.

Our medical examination followed a familiar routine.

Eye test.

Hearing test.

Height.

Weight.

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Blood sample.

Urine sample.

Nothing complicated.

Nothing remarkable.

Yet it felt significant.

Every completed test was another small step away from college life and closer to becoming an engineer.

The reports would take time to prepare, so we were asked to return later.

As we stepped outside, Arvind looked at the rest of us.

“Hostel?”

I looked back at him.

“Hostel?”

He seemed surprised.

“You didn’t know?”

I shook my head.

“The company has arranged accommodation for all of us.”

For a moment I simply stood there.

The previous night I had paid for a hotel room near the bus stand because I hadn’t known where to go after reaching Haridwar.

Apparently, I could have walked into the Engineer Trainee Hostel and stayed there free of cost.

I laughed at myself.

It was an expensive lesson.

But perhaps every newcomer pays a small price for not knowing how things work.

We collected our luggage and headed towards the hostel together.

By then, something had quietly changed.

That morning I had entered the administrative building alone.

By afternoon, I was walking with friends.

The Engineer Trainee Hostel

The Engineer Trainee Hostel stood only a short walk from the hospital, tucked away behind rows of trees that softened the otherwise orderly layout of the township.

From the outside, it looked like any other government hostel—simple, practical and without any attempt to impress. But as we walked through its entrance carrying our suitcases, I had the feeling that this building would become far more than just a place to sleep.

I had spent four years of engineering college away from home, but never in a hostel.

Hostel life had always remained slightly beyond my reach.

My family's finances simply couldn't stretch that far. Instead, three friends and I rented a small room near the college and split every expense we could. It wasn't glamorous, but it was affordable, and at that stage of life affordability mattered far more than comfort.

So, strangely enough, at the age of twenty-three, standing in front of the Engineer Trainee Hostel at BHEL, I was about to experience hostel life for the very first time.

I wasn't entering just another building.

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I was stepping into something I had quietly missed during my college years

The corridors echoed with the sounds of conversations in half a dozen languages. Suitcases lay outside open doors. Someone was struggling to fit a bedsheet over a mattress while another argued with the caretaker about room allotments. Laughter drifted from somewhere upstairs. Every face carried the same mixture of excitement and uncertainty that I had seen in the HR office earlier that morning.

The difference was that here, everyone had begun to relax.

One of the senior trainees guided us through the registration formalities before handing over our room numbers.

“For now,” he explained, “rooms will be shared. A sports event is coming up, so accommodation is tight. Once it is over, single rooms will be allotted.”

That sounded perfectly reasonable.

After spending three days sharing space with strangers on trains and buses, sharing a room no longer seemed like a sacrifice.

Arvind and Sandeep were allotted the room next to mine.

Before unpacking their own belongings, they helped me carry my suitcase upstairs.

Inside, my room was simple but comfortable.

Two single cots stood against opposite walls, each with a mattress and pillow neatly arranged. Built into the wall were two steel cupboards, waiting to be claimed by whoever occupied them. A wooden study table occupied one corner with a single chair pushed underneath it. Beside the window sat a worn but comfortable cushioned chair that had clearly witnessed generations of engineer trainees before us.

There was nothing luxurious about the room.

Yet after the previous week's journey, it felt almost perfect.

My roommate had not yet arrived, so I chose the bed nearest the window and began unpacking.

Arvind looked around the room and smiled.

"Not bad."

I agreed.

Unlike many of my batchmates, I had no idea what hostel life was supposed to feel like.

Everything was new—the shared rooms, the common mess, the notice boards, the seniors, the unwritten rules that everyone else seemed to know instinctively.

I wasn't nervous.

I was curious.

Comfort wasn't measured by furniture.

It was measured by the people around you.

Before long, my roommate finally arrived.

He introduced himself as Vivek Saxena, from Bareilly.

Soft-spoken, polite and remarkably composed, Vivek immediately struck me as someone with a clear plan for his future. During our first conversation, he admitted that joining BHEL had never been his final ambition.

"IIM," he said simply.

He intended to prepare for the entrance examinations while working.

As the months went by, I would discover that he wasn't alone.

Several trainees viewed BHEL not as their destination but as a stepping stone toward management schools or the Civil Services.

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Life, however, often has its own plans for people who are busy making theirs.

By afternoon, hunger finally reminded me that I had barely eaten since arriving in Haridwar.

The hostel operated differently from anything I had experienced before.

Meals weren't simply served to whoever happened to arrive. Every resident informed the cook in advance whether they would be eating, and the expenses were shared among everyone staying there. Since I had checked in only that morning, no lunch had been prepared for me.

The cook looked genuinely apologetic.

"If only you'd told us in the morning..."

It wasn't anyone's fault.

It was simply another rule I hadn't yet learned.

Another unwritten hostel rule.

Meals weren't cooked for whoever happened to arrive.

They were cooked only for those who had informed the cook in advance.

Nobody had told me.

But then, how could they?

I was learning hostel life one small lesson at a time.

So the three of us walked towards the small market outside the township in search of lunch.

As we ate at a modest roadside restaurant, conversation flowed much more easily than it had during the hospital visit.

We spoke about our colleges.

Our hometowns.

Our interviews.

The endless wait for appointment letters.

The uncertainty of campus placements.

For the first time since leaving Chennai, I wasn't introducing myself to strangers anymore.

I was talking to friends.

That evening, another problem presented itself.

Winter.

The mattress was comfortable enough.

The pillow was adequate.

But one essential item was missing.

A quilt.

Seeing my puzzled expression, Arvind laughed.

"You'll freeze tonight."

Sandeep nodded in agreement.

"We're going to Jwalapur this evening. Come with us."

As daylight slowly faded behind the trees of the township, the three of us set out towards the bustling markets of Jwalapur.

I had arrived in Haridwar believing I knew how to begin a career.

Instead, my first lesson had been much simpler.

Sometimes growing up begins with buying your own blanket.

Learning to Belong

The first few days at BHEL settled into a rhythm surprisingly quickly.

Every morning began the same way. After breakfast in the hostel mess, our batch of Engineer Trainees would walk together to the Human Resource Development Centre—better known simply as the HRDC.

That was where our journey as engineers truly began.

The classrooms weren't intimidating. The instructors weren't trying to overwhelm us with technical jargon. Instead, the induction was designed to introduce us to the organisation, its history, its products and, more importantly, the culture we were now becoming part of.

For the first time, I wasn't thinking about getting a job.

I already had one.

Now I had to learn how to deserve it.

The HRDC was headed by Mr. Prakash Pant.

He carried himself with quiet authority, but unlike many senior officers, he never made fresh graduates feel insignificant.

Looking back, I think he noticed something that others didn't.

I was the only trainee who had travelled nearly two thousand kilometres from home.

Whether it was concern or simple kindness, he always seemed to have a few extra words for me whenever our paths crossed.

"How are you settling down?"

"Everything alright in the hostel?"

Simple questions.

But when you're far away from home for the first time, simple questions matter.

Being the only South Indian in the batch had its advantages.

Everyone remembered my name.

It also had its challenges.

Everyone expected me to understand Hindi better than I actually did.

I could follow conversations reasonably well.

Speaking was another matter.

Every sentence required planning.

Every reply involved translating my thoughts from Tamil to English and then searching for the right Hindi words before speaking.

By the time I found them, the conversation had usually moved on.

Numbers were my greatest enemy.

Words could often be guessed from context.

Numbers couldn't.

The first few visits to shops around the township became small adventures.

I'd pick up something I wanted to buy.

The shopkeeper would announce the price.

I would stare blankly for a moment before smiling sheepishly.

"Kitne rupay..."

He would repeat it.

Slightly louder.

As though volume could overcome language.

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Finally, I'd smile and say,

“English mein bataiye.”

Sometimes the shopkeeper laughed.

Sometimes he looked puzzled.

Sometimes another customer would quietly translate.

On a few occasions, my friends stepped in before I even had to ask.

It became a familiar routine.

One that embarrassed me far more than it amused anyone else.

The surprising part was that nobody made me feel unwelcome.

Whenever I struggled to find a word, someone completed the sentence.

Whenever I misunderstood directions, someone walked with me instead.

Whenever I looked confused by local customs, someone explained them without making me feel foolish.

Friendship, I discovered, often begins with small acts of patience.

Hostel life also had its own language.

There were unwritten rules that everyone else seemed to understand instinctively.

You informed the cook before meals.

You signed your name for shared expenses.

You borrowed newspapers without asking, but always returned them neatly folded.

Tea appeared almost magically whenever conversations became interesting.

Somebody always knew where to buy something cheaper.

Somebody always knew whom to ask for help.

Unlike college, where four of us had rented a room simply because it was all we could afford, this was my first experience of living in a real hostel.

It was an entirely different world.

There was a rhythm to it.

People came and went without ceremony.

Doors remained half open.

Conversations drifted from one room to another.

Nobody waited for an invitation to pull up a chair.

The hostel somehow managed to create privacy and companionship at the same time.

I found myself enjoying it more than I had expected.

One evening, after another visit to the market in Jwalapur, I realised something unusual.

The shopkeeper had quoted the price.

I had understood it immediately.

Without translating.

Without asking anyone.

Without saying, “English mein bataiye.”

It was such a small victory that nobody else noticed.

I didn’t mention it to my friends.

There was nothing to celebrate.

And yet, as we walked back towards the hostel under the cold January sky, I caught myself smiling.

Perhaps this was how belonging happened.

Not all at once.

Not with grand gestures.

Just one conversation...

...one new word...

...and one ordinary day at a time.

Anywhere

Life at the Engineer Trainee Hostel settled into a comfortable rhythm much faster than I had expected.

The unfamiliar faces from my first morning had become familiar voices. Doors remained open more often than they stayed closed. Tea appeared whenever someone suggested it, and conversations stretched late into the evenings before giving way to another day of training.

Every morning we walked together to the Human Resource Development Centre.

Every evening we walked back together.

Without realising it, we had begun moving like a single batch instead of thirty individuals.

The induction programme continued for several weeks, introducing us not just to BHEL but to the philosophy behind an organisation that had helped build much of India's industrial backbone.

We learned about turbines, generators, boilers and manufacturing plants.

But outside the classroom, we learned something equally valuable.

We learned one another.

One morning, towards the end of our induction programme, Mr. Prakash walked into the classroom carrying a file.

The room became unusually quiet.

Whenever a senior officer entered carrying a file, everyone instinctively assumed that something important was about to happen.

He smiled before speaking.

“The next phase of your training will be rotational.”

A murmur spread across the room.

This had been mentioned before, but nobody knew what it actually meant.

He explained that every Engineer Trainee would spend time in another BHEL unit before returning to Haridwar. The idea was simple. Exposure to different plants, different people and different ways of working would produce better engineers.

It sounded exciting.

Until the destinations were announced.

The Haridwar batch would be divided into two groups.

One group would travel to Hyderabad.

The other would travel to Tiruchirapalli.

Most of my friends immediately became busy calculating where they might end up.

Some preferred Hyderabad.

Others wanted Trichy.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Everyone suddenly had an opinion.

I smiled quietly.

For me, either destination felt equally welcome.

A question from several months earlier suddenly returned to my mind.

During my interview in Bangalore, one of the panel members had looked up from my application and asked,

“Where would you like to be posted if selected?”

It was a dangerous question.

A wrong answer could easily be interpreted as reluctance.

So I had replied without thinking twice.

“Anywhere.”

At twenty-three, it was simply the safest answer an unemployed graduate could give.

Looking back now, I often smile at how seriously life decided to take me.

The allocation was based on alphabetical order.

Names beginning from A to P would proceed to Tiruchirapalli.

The remaining trainees would report to Hyderabad.

Technically, I belonged in the Hyderabad group.

Then something unexpected happened.

Mr. Prakash looked towards me.

“Ravi...”

He paused for a moment.

“You’ve already travelled all the way from Chennai.”

He glanced down at the list.

“It will probably be easier if you go to Trichy.”

With a few strokes of his pen, my name exchanged places with another trainee.

Just like that.

No request.

No application.

No lobbying.

Only a thoughtful decision made by someone who had quietly observed the young engineer from Chennai trying to find his place.

At the time, I accepted it as an administrative adjustment.

Years later, I understood it differently.

Sometimes the people who influence our lives the most never realise they have done so.

The classroom erupted into conversations.

Travel plans.

Packing.

Train reservations.

Speculation about the two plants.

For me, however, the excitement carried a different meaning.

I wasn’t simply travelling to another BHEL unit.

I was going back to a city that already knew me.

Trichy.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

The city where I had spent four unforgettable years as an engineering student.

The streets.

The buses.

The tea stalls.

The familiar Tamil conversations.

After weeks of struggling through Hindi, I would once again be surrounded by my own language.

For the first time since arriving in Haridwar, I felt a small wave of homesickness beginning to lift.

I wasn't going home.

But I was certainly going somewhere that felt like it.

That evening, as we returned to the hostel, everyone talked about the coming journey.

I found myself smiling more than speaking.

Life had a curious habit of moving me farther away from home...

...only to occasionally reward me by bringing me unexpectedly close again.

Chapter 4 - Discovering India

Returning to Trichy

The weeks between the announcement and our departure passed surprisingly quickly.

The hostel became unusually busy.

Suitcases reappeared from beneath beds. Lists were made. Train tickets were checked and rechecked. Some trainees worried about what to pack.

Others worried about what awaited them.

I had only one thought.

I was going back to Trichy.

Only a year earlier I had left the city carrying an engineering degree and a great deal of uncertainty.

Back then I was another graduate standing in a crowded bus stand, wondering where life would take me next.

This time I was returning with something I hadn't possessed then.

An identity.

I was no longer a student.

I was an Engineer Trainee with Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited.

It felt different.

Not because the city had changed.

Because I had.

Our journey south felt very different from my first journey north.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

When I had travelled from Chennai to Delhi in January, I knew nobody.

Every station had felt unfamiliar.

Every conversation had demanded courage.

Now I travelled with friends.

The same people who had been strangers outside the Human Resources office only weeks earlier had become companions whose habits I already knew.

Someone always carried extra snacks.

Someone invariably misplaced a ticket.

Someone could never resist starting a debate that lasted half the journey.

Laughter replaced the silence that had accompanied my first long train ride.

The distance remained the same.

The journey became shorter.

As the train rolled deeper into South India, something else quietly changed.

The signboards.

The conversations on the platforms.

The vendors calling out to passengers.

Tamil slowly replaced Hindi.

Without thinking, I found myself answering questions more quickly.

Ordering tea no longer required rehearsing sentences in my head.

I understood every announcement before anyone else did.

For the first time in weeks, language demanded no effort.

It simply existed around me.

I hadn't realised how mentally exhausting translation had become until it was suddenly unnecessary.

When the train finally approached Tiruchirapalli, I found myself looking eagerly through the window.

The landscape felt wonderfully familiar.

Roads I had travelled as a student.

Buildings I recognised from bus rides.

Temples whose silhouettes had once blended into ordinary life.

It was remarkable how quickly a city could become part of you without your noticing.

There is a peculiar feeling that comes with returning to a place after your life has changed.

Nothing appears different.

Yet everything does.

The tea stall outside the station still served the same strong filter coffee.

The buses still groaned under impossible crowds.

The afternoon sun still wrapped the city in the same warm haze.

But I was seeing it through different eyes.

During college, every journey through these streets had been accompanied by questions.

Would I pass?

Would I find a job?

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Would I make something of myself?

Now one of those questions had already been answered.

Quietly.

Without celebration.

Somewhere between Haridwar and this railway platform, uncertainty had given way to confidence.

The BHEL hostel in Trichy welcomed trainees from different units across the country.

Within a day, new friendships began to form.

Among them were trainees from Delhi who would spend the next two months learning alongside us.

Conversations soon shifted from introductions to comparisons.

Whose winters were colder.

Whose food was better.

Which city had the worst traffic.

Every debate ended with laughter and absolutely no agreement.

Exactly as good friendships should.

That evening, after settling into my room, I stepped outside alone.

The warm March breeze felt wonderfully familiar after the cold winter of Haridwar.

Somewhere in the distance I could hear the evening temple bells.

For a few minutes I simply stood there, breathing in the air of the city that had shaped me.

I realised something then.

Home isn't always the place where you were born.

Sometimes it's the place where you first discovered who you could become.

And for me...

Trichy would always be one of those places.

Coming Home Different

March had always been my favourite month.

Not because of examinations ending.

Not because summer was approaching.

Simply because it was my birthday.

This year, however, March carried a different meaning.

For the first time in my life, I wasn't returning home as a student.

I was returning as someone who had begun earning his own living.

When our rotational training at Trichy began, I immediately noticed something that made me smile.

My birthday would fall on a Saturday.

That meant I could take a bus to Chennai on Friday evening, spend the weekend with my family, and return before training resumed on Monday.

It felt like a gift.

Not from BHEL.

From the calendar itself.

The bus ride from Trichy to Chennai had once been an ordinary journey during my college days.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

I had travelled that route countless times carrying books, laundry and unfinished assignments.

This journey felt different.

My luggage was lighter.

My thoughts were heavier.

Somewhere in my bag lay two salary slips.

I found myself taking them out more than once during the journey.

Not because of the amount.

But because they represented something I had dreamed about for years.

Employment.

Responsibility.

Independence.

When the bus finally pulled into Chennai that night, everything looked exactly as I had left it.

The familiar streets.

The familiar traffic.

The familiar humidity that instantly replaced the dry warmth of Trichy.

Some cities don't welcome you.

They simply continue loving you as though you had never left.

Home was like that.

My mother opened the door before I could knock twice.

The smile on her face erased every kilometre I had travelled.

Inside, nothing had changed.

The same furniture.

The same photographs.

The same smell of home-cooked food drifting from the kitchen.

My younger sister wanted to hear every story from Haridwar.

How cold was it?

Did it snow?

How big was the factory?

What was hostel life like?

My father listened quietly.

He always preferred listening before speaking.

Over dinner I found myself talking far more than eating.

The food.

The winter.

The hostel.

My new friends.

Learning Hindi.

The company township.

Mr. Prakash.

Each story led naturally to another.

Somewhere during the conversation I realised something.

For the first time, my parents weren't worrying about whether I would find a job.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

That chapter had quietly closed.

The next morning was my birthday.

No grand celebration.

No expensive gifts.

Just my family together.

Looking back now, I realise those simple birthdays became rarer as life grew busier.

At twenty-three, I took them for granted.

At fifty, I treasure them.

There was another quiet change that I noticed during that visit.

Until then, every rupee I had spent came from my father.

Now I carried my own salary.

The amount wasn't extraordinary.

The feeling was.

For the first time in my life, I wasn't simply a son.

I had become an earning member of the family.

That responsibility didn't feel heavy.

It felt like a privilege.

Sunday disappeared far too quickly.

As evening approached, I packed my bag once again.

Monday's training awaited me in Trichy.

My father insisted on accompanying me to the bus stand.

He didn't say much.

Neither did I.

Some goodbyes have never needed many words.

As the bus slowly pulled away, I looked through the window.

There he stood.

Watching until the bus disappeared into traffic.

I had seen pride in my father's eyes before.

That evening...

I saw peace.

And somehow, that meant even more.

Colours Without Language

Until I moved to North India, Holi belonged to Hindi films.

Growing up in Chennai, I knew the festival well enough. Every year television channels showed colourful crowds dancing through the streets while Bollywood heroes chased one another with buckets of coloured water. Newspapers carried photographs of smiling faces that were almost impossible to recognise beneath layers of pink, green and purple.

It looked entertaining.

It also looked wonderfully distant.

In the South, festivals had a different rhythm.

We celebrated Pongal with freshly harvested rice, Deepavali with lamps and fireworks, and Tamil New Year with family gatherings. Clothes were chosen carefully. Homes were cleaned meticulously. Looking presentable was part of the celebration itself.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

If someone walked towards you carrying coloured powder in Chennai, instinct usually took over.

You ran.

Not because you disliked the person.

Simply because nobody wanted freshly washed clothes ruined before breakfast.

So, somewhere in my mind, I had quietly assumed Holi was something people watched more than they celebrated.

Haridwar had already taught me not to make assumptions about North India.

Trichy was about to reinforce the lesson.

The evening before Holi, the hostel was unusually lively.

Buckets appeared in the corridors.

Packets of coloured powder seemed to materialise from nowhere.

Groups gathered in corners whispering plans that immediately stopped whenever someone else walked past.

It didn't require much intelligence to realise something was being planned.

It required even less intelligence to realise I was probably part of it.

I wisely decided not to ask any questions.

The next morning began suspiciously quietly.

Too quietly.

The corridors, normally filled with voices, were almost silent.

I stepped out of my room wondering whether everyone had already left.

Then I heard it.

“Ravi!”

I turned instinctively.

That was my mistake.

A cloud of bright pink colour exploded across my face before I had taken my second step into the corridor.

Laughter erupted from every direction.

Before I could even identify my attacker, someone else smeared green colour across my cheeks while another emptied a mug of coloured water over my shoulders.

Within seconds, my carefully chosen clothes had surrendered completely.

There was no point protecting them anymore.

The battle had already been lost.

For the first few minutes, I reacted exactly as any young man from Chennai would.

I tried to stay clean.

I avoided the buckets.

I attempted to negotiate.

“Enough... enough!”

Nobody paid the slightest attention.

Apparently, those words held no legal validity on Holi.

Somewhere between the third bucket of coloured water and the fifth handful of gulal, something unexpected happened.

I stopped worrying.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

The colour was already everywhere.

On my clothes.

In my hair.

Across my face.

Even my hands had become colours I couldn't identify anymore.

There was nothing left to protect.

So I did the only sensible thing.

I picked up a handful of colour myself.

Within minutes, I was chasing the very people I had been trying to escape only moments earlier.

What surprised me most wasn't the colours.

It was the laughter.

Nobody cared where anyone came from.

Nobody cared who spoke Hindi, Tamil or English.

Nobody cared which engineering college we had graduated from.

For a few hours, every one of us looked exactly the same.

Completely unrecognisable.

Perhaps that was Holi's greatest gift.

It removed every label before adding colour.

By afternoon, the hostel resembled a battlefield that had somehow ended in universal happiness.

Buckets lay overturned.

The courtyard had transformed into a rainbow of muddy footprints.

Faces were still impossible to recognise.

Someone looked at me and laughed.

“You don’t look like a South Indian anymore.”

I laughed too.

“I’m not sure I look like a human being anymore.”

Cleaning ourselves afterwards proved almost as memorable as the celebration itself.

No amount of soap seemed capable of removing every trace of colour.

Pink ears remained pink.

Blue fingernails refused to cooperate.

For days afterwards, tiny patches of green continued appearing in unexpected places.

Every morning the mirror reminded me that Holi wasn’t a festival that ended in one day.

It preferred leaving souvenirs.

That evening, after the excitement had settled, I sat outside the hostel with a cup of tea.

The corridors were finally quiet again.

The colours had mostly disappeared from the walls.

They hadn’t disappeared from me.

I realised I had spent twenty-three years believing I understood my country.

Moving two thousand kilometres away had taught me otherwise.

India wasn’t one culture waiting to be understood.

It was many cultures waiting to be experienced.

And the remarkable thing was that none of those experiences asked me to give up who I already was.

They simply invited me to become a little more than I had been yesterday.

The Bus That Left

A few of the fellow engineer trainees expressed their interest in going to Tirupati. Growing up in Chennai, Tirupati had always been close enough to feel familiar.

Friends and relatives spoke about it often. Calendars carried pictures of Lord Venkateswara. Boxes of Tirupati laddus occasionally found their way into our home whenever someone returned from a pilgrimage.

Yet strangely enough...

I had never been there.

Like many things in my twenties, this too would be a first.

When the opportunity came i needed no further persuasion. A pilgrimage, a road trip and a weekend away with friends...

It sounded like the perfect combination.

The overnight bus left Trichy long after dinner.

As always, the excitement lasted barely an hour. One by one conversations faded. Someone leaned against the window. Someone stretched across two seats. Within minutes the rhythmic hum of the engine had done what no classroom ever could.

It put almost everyone to sleep. Including me.

Sometime before dawn, I vaguely heard the conductor calling out.

“Tirupati... Tirupati...”

Still half asleep, I instinctively reached for my bag. Without thinking, I stepped off the bus. The cool morning air woke me just enough to stretch and look around.

Then the bus pulled away. I watched it disappear.

Only then did I realise something.

I hadn't looked back. Not once. I had simply assumed my friends were behind me.

They weren't.

Still fast asleep, they had remained on the bus.

For a few moments I stood there, staring at the road where the bus had disappeared.

No mobile phones. No messages. No way of knowing where they would get down or how long it would take them to realise I was missing.

It was just me.

A small bag.

And Tirupati waking up around me.

Oddly enough, I wasn't frightened. More puzzled than anything else. I smiled to myself.

"What now?"

After asking a few people for directions, I made my way towards the temple.

Pilgrims had already begun their climb.

Families walked together.

Children fought sleep while clutching their parents' hands.

The atmosphere carried a quiet sense of purpose.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Everyone had come with a prayer.

Everyone carried something invisible.

Like many devotees before me, I decided to offer my hair.

Until then, a tonsured head had always been something I had seen on other pilgrims.

That morning, sitting quietly as the barber worked with practiced ease, I experienced the ritual for the first time myself.

There is something deeply humbling about it.

For a few minutes, appearances no longer matter.

Status no longer matters.

You surrender something that has quietly become part of your identity.

Not because it is required.

Because it reminds you that gratitude often asks us to let go of a little pride.

After taking a bath and changing into fresh clothes, I walked out feeling unexpectedly light.

The crowds seemed even larger now.

Thousands of pilgrims moved in every direction. Some arriving. Some leaving. Some searching for family members.

I smiled at the thought.

I wondered where my friends might be by now.

Then, quite suddenly...

I saw them walking towards me. They could not have recognized me as I had tonsured my head, But I recognised them.

For a moment none of us spoke.

Then all of us burst into laughter.

“You got down!”

“You never woke us!”

“You disappeared!”

Each of us blamed the other with complete confidence. None of us was entirely innocent. They had travelled several kilometres before realising I wasn't on the bus. By the time they managed to return to Tirupati, they had no idea where to begin searching.

Neither did I.

Yet somehow...

In a town filled with thousands upon thousands of pilgrims...

Our paths crossed again.

Naturally.

Effortlessly.

Almost as though they had never separated.

Even today, when I think about that morning, I don't remember the confusion.

I remember the feeling.

At twenty-three, I accepted it as one of those happy coincidences life occasionally offers.

Years later, I find myself looking at it differently.

Faith doesn't always arrive as miracles.

Sometimes it appears quietly...

...in the form of familiar faces appearing in an unfamiliar crowd.

The return journey to Trichy was far less adventurous.
This time, before getting off the bus...
I made absolutely certain everyone else was getting off too.
Some lessons stay with you forever.
Others stay with your friends forever.
Mine happened to do both.

Chasing the Sun

There comes a time in every young engineer's life when a salary is no longer just money.
It becomes possibility.
For us, that possibility arrived in the form of a simple question.
"What are we doing this weekend?"
Someone suggested Kanyakumari.
Someone else immediately added Kovalam.
Within minutes the plan had grown wildly ambitious.
Leave Trichy on Friday evening.
Watch the sunrise at Kanyakumari on Saturday morning.
Drive to Kovalam.
Watch the sunset there the very same evening.
Spend the night by the beach.
Return to Trichy before work resumed on Monday.
Looking back, it sounds wonderfully unrealistic.
At twenty-three...

it sounded perfectly achievable.

There were more than ten of us, so we hired a minivan.

To an outsider it was just another white vehicle waiting outside the hostel.

To us, it was freedom on four wheels.

Bags were thrown into the back.

Seats were claimed with unnecessary seriousness.

Someone argued about the window seat.

Someone insisted on sitting near the driver.

The driver watched us with the patient expression of a man who had probably transported groups like ours many times before.

He had no idea what he had signed up for.

Every road trip has its soundtrack.

Ours belonged to Kishore Kumar.

Ajit had arrived carrying a small collection of well-loved audio cassettes, and before the van had even left Trichy, one had already found its way into the cassette player.

The familiar voice filled the van.

One song became another.

Then another.

By the end of the weekend we no longer needed to guess what came next.

We knew the order by heart.

Someone sang confidently.

Someone sang terribly.

Nobody cared.

The songs belonged to all of us.

Even today, whenever I hear a Kishore Kumar melody, my mind doesn't return to a music player.

It returns to that minivan speeding through Tamil Nadu with a group of young engineers who believed an entire weekend was enough to conquer South India.

As darkness settled outside, conversations wandered from college memories to future ambitions.

Some wanted to pursue higher studies.

Some dreamed of overseas assignments.

Some were simply happy to have finally escaped unemployment.

Every dream felt equally possible.

Perhaps that is another privilege of youth.

The future always seems larger than the road ahead.

Somewhere between Trichy and Madurai, our journey acquired a performance.

The van slowed to a halt at a traffic signal.

The music continued playing.

Without the slightest warning, Ajit stood up.

Grabbing the support pole inside the minivan, he transformed it into a dance floor.

For the next few moments he danced with complete commitment, perfectly in rhythm with Kishore Kumar's voice.

Passengers in neighbouring buses stopped talking.

Auto-rickshaw drivers stared in amused disbelief.

Even a cyclist waiting beside us couldn't hide his smile.

Inside our van, laughter erupted so loudly that several of us struggled to breathe.

The traffic signal turned green.

The van rolled forward.

Ajit never missed a beat.

To this day, whenever I think of that journey, I cannot remember which song was playing.

But I can still remember the expressions on the faces outside our windows.

The highways stretched endlessly before us.

Occasionally we stopped for tea.

Sometimes for dinner.

Sometimes simply because someone wanted to stretch.

The night slipped away beneath headlights, laughter and old Hindi songs.

Every passing kilometre carried us closer to the southernmost tip of the Indian mainland.

None of us slept very much.

None of us wanted to.

Some journeys deserve to be experienced with tired eyes.

Just before dawn, the driver pointed ahead.

“Kanyakumari.”

Almost instantly the van came alive.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Curtains were pulled aside.

Sleep disappeared.

Cameras emerged.

Someone checked the time.

Someone reminded us that we had made it exactly as planned.

The horizon was still dark.

The sea waited silently.

And somewhere beyond it...

the sun was preparing to begin another day.

We had come all this way to watch it rise.

Where Three Seas Meet

There are very few places in India where people willingly wake up before sunrise.

Kanyakumari is one of them.

Long before dawn, hundreds of visitors had already gathered along the shoreline, quietly waiting for the first light of the day. Some carried cameras. Others simply stood with folded arms, looking towards the endless horizon where the Bay of Bengal, the Arabian Sea and the Indian Ocean met.

The conversations around us slowly faded.

Nature was about to begin its daily performance.

And nobody wanted to miss the opening act.

The first hint of orange appeared almost unnoticed.

Then another.

Within minutes the dark horizon transformed into a canvas of colours that no camera could ever capture completely.

Someone beside me whispered,

“There...”

As though the sun needed an introduction.

Then it appeared.

Slowly.

Almost reluctantly.

Rising out of the sea with a quiet confidence that made the entire crowd forget to speak.

For a few precious minutes, complete strangers stood together in silence, watching the beginning of another day.

Some experiences don't need conversation.

They create their own.

We had achieved the first half of our ambitious plan.

Sunrise at Kanyakumari.

One destination complete.

One more still waiting.

But before leaving, we wanted proof that we had been there.

Naturally...

someone suggested a group photograph.

A cluster of rocks near the shoreline offered the perfect backdrop.

The rising sun behind us.

The sea stretching endlessly into the distance.

The photographer positioned us carefully.

“Taller people at the back.”

“You... move a little left.”

“No... not that much.”

Like every group photograph ever taken, it took far longer to organise than to capture.

There was one small difference between me and everyone else.

The previous weekend at Tirupati had left me with a completely shaved head.

While everyone else fought the sea breeze trying to keep their hair in place...

I had no such concerns.

My freshly tonsured head reflected the morning sunlight with remarkable efficiency.

Naturally, this became the subject of several jokes.

I accepted them with good humour.

There wasn't much else I could do.

The photographer finally raised the camera.

“Ready...”

We smiled.

Then...

without the slightest warning...

the sea decided it wanted to be part of the photograph.

A massive wave crashed against the rocks beneath us.

For one unforgettable second, everything disappeared into white water.

People slipped.

Someone shouted.

Someone grabbed another person's arm.

The carefully arranged group collapsed into complete chaos.

I lost my balance, stumbled against the rocks and felt my spectacles disappear into the water.

By the time the wave retreated, everyone was soaked from head to toe.

Thankfully, apart from a small bruise near my ear and the loss of my glasses, nobody was seriously hurt.

The photographer, however, stood there laughing so hard that he could barely hold the camera.

Needless to say...

That wasn't the photograph we had planned.

But it became the memory we all kept.

After changing into dry clothes and sharing one last look at the sea, we climbed back into the minivan.

There was no time to linger.

The second half of our weekend still awaited us.

If everything went according to plan, we would watch another sunset.

This time...

from Kovalam.

The driver started the engine.

Someone reached for the cassette player.

Within seconds, Kishore Kumar was singing once again.

The road stretched ahead.

And so did another adventure.

Racing the Sunset

The sunrise at Kanyakumari had been only half the challenge.

The real test still lay ahead.

Our ambitious weekend plan depended on reaching Kovalam before the sun disappeared into the Arabian Sea. We had spent longer than expected exploring Kanyakumari, taking photographs, laughing over our unexpected encounter with the waves, and simply enjoying being there.

Every extra minute now worked against us.

The calculations inside the minivan became increasingly optimistic.

“We’ll make it.”

“If traffic cooperates.”

“We only need a few more minutes.”

Nobody suggested giving up.

After all, if we had managed to catch the sunrise, surely we could catch the sunset too.

The roads into Kerala seemed unusually long that afternoon.

Every slow-moving bus looked like an obstacle.

Every traffic signal felt unnecessary.

Every passing minute made us glance at the western sky.

Even the driver understood our mission.

Without needing many instructions, he kept the van moving steadily while the rest of us became unofficial navigators, constantly asking how much farther remained.

As we entered Kovalam, someone asked the obvious question.

“Should we find the hotel first?”

The answer came instantly.

“No... beach first!”

There would be time later to check in.

Time later to wash up.

Time later to unpack our bags.

There would not be another sunset.

The driver smiled, nodded, and steered the minivan straight towards the beach.

When we finally stepped out, we barely noticed how tired we were.

The sea was already glowing in shades of gold and orange.

People lined the shore, watching the evening unfold.

We hurried across the sand like children afraid of missing the final scene of a movie.

And then...

we stopped.

The sun was still there.

Waiting.

For a few quiet moments, none of us spoke.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

We had done it.

Within a single weekend, we had watched the sun rise over the Bay of Bengal and set over the Arabian Sea.

It felt like a small victory.

Not over nature.

But over our own ambitious plan.

Only after the last sliver of sunlight disappeared below the horizon did practical thoughts return.

We looked at one another and laughed.

None of us had a hotel.

None of us had freshened up since morning.

We had arrived carrying luggage, cameras, tired faces and an unreasonable sense of accomplishment.

Only then did we ask the driver to find us a place to stay.

Priorities, after all, are different when you're twenty-three.

Our lodge stood only a short walk from the beach.

From the outside it was modest.

Inside, it offered everything we needed—a place to sleep, a shower to wash away the salt and dust of the journey, and a balcony where the sound of the waves replaced the traffic we had left behind.

It wasn't luxury.

It didn't need to be.

For one weekend, the sea itself was enough.

That evening drifted by without any grand plans.

We walked along the shoreline, replaying the events of the previous twenty-four hours.

Ajit's dance performance inside the minivan was recreated several times, each retelling making it even more dramatic than the original.

Someone claimed the wave at Kanyakumari had reached shoulder height.

Someone else insisted it was taller than the van.

Memory has always been generous with dimensions.

As darkness settled over Kovalam, I found myself thinking about how quickly life had changed.

Just a few months earlier I had been waiting anxiously for a job offer.

Now I was travelling across South India with friends I hadn't even known at the beginning of the year.

Engineering had brought us together.

The journey was slowly turning us into a family.

Tomorrow afternoon we would head back to Trichy.

But for now...

there was nowhere else we would rather be.

Sunday Morning at Kovalam

For the first time since leaving Trichy, there was nowhere we needed to rush.

The sunrise had been witnessed.

The sunset had been conquered.

The impossible weekend itinerary had somehow worked exactly as we had imagined.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Sunday morning belonged entirely to us.

Our lodge stood only a few steps away from the beach.

The sound of the waves had replaced alarm clocks, and nobody seemed particularly interested in knowing what time it was.

Some wandered towards the shoreline with cameras.

Others simply stretched, enjoying the luxury of an unhurried morning before the long drive back to Trichy.

A few of us settled into one of the small beach shacks overlooking the sea.

The owner had arranged a handful of wooden tables facing the water, the kind of place where people could sit for hours doing absolutely nothing and still feel they had spent the day well.

We ordered a few beers and settled into our chairs.

The sea breeze carried the smell of salt, grilled fish from nearby stalls, and the occasional burst of laughter from tourists already enjoying the beach.

For once, nobody was discussing work, training schedules or future postings.

The only agenda that morning was to enjoy the moment.

As we sat there talking, someone noticed a lone foreign tourist walking along the beach towards our shack.

He wore shorts, a light T-shirt and carried himself with the relaxed confidence of someone who had nowhere to be except by the sea.

We watched him absent-mindedly while continuing our conversation.

As he came closer, someone remarked,

“Looks like another European backpacker.”

Nobody paid much attention.

After all, Kovalam was known for attracting visitors from around the world.

The stranger kept walking towards us.

Closer.

Closer.

Then someone suddenly frowned.

“Wait...”

Another leaned forward.

“No...”

“It can’t be...”

A few more steps.

And then the entire table burst into laughter.

It wasn’t a foreign tourist at all.

It was Arvind.

Somewhere that morning, he had wandered off on his own, picked up a pair of sunglasses, relaxed into the beach atmosphere, and unknowingly returned looking so much like one of the foreign visitors that none of us had recognised him from a distance.

Naturally, he spent the rest of the day listening to jokes about his “international transformation.”

He accepted them with remarkable patience.

I suspect he had little choice.

Eventually reality reminded us that Monday was waiting.

The bags were packed once more.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

The minivan was loaded.

The cassette player was ready.

As we drove away from Kovalam, the beach slowly disappeared in the rear-view mirror.

The laughter, however, travelled with us all the way back to Trichy.

Looking back, I remember surprisingly little about the lodge itself.

I don't remember the room number.

I don't remember what we paid.

I don't even remember what we had for breakfast.

But I remember that morning.

I remember the sea.

I remember the conversations.

And I remember a friend who, for a few unforgettable minutes, convinced an entire table that a foreign tourist had decided to join us for a drink.

Memory has an amusing way of preserving exactly what matters.

Chapter 5 - Finding My Place

The Posting List

Returning to Haridwar after our South India trip felt different.

A few weeks earlier, I had arrived as a nervous trainee trying to remember names, understand Hindi, and find my way around an unfamiliar campus.

Now the faces were familiar.

The corridors no longer felt intimidating.

I knew people across different training batches and departments. A walk across the township often meant stopping every few minutes to exchange greetings with someone I had met during our rotations.

Somewhere along the way, Haridwar had quietly become home.

The next milestone in our training was departmental allocation.

Until then, we had rotated through different divisions to understand how BHEL functioned as an organization. Now it was time to be assigned to the departments where we would begin our actual careers.

For me, there was very little suspense.

I had graduated in Computer Science.

Naturally, I expected to join ITX.

The posting list appeared on the notice board one morning.

Like every important notice in BHEL, it drew a crowd before anyone had managed to read it properly.

Some trainees smiled as they found their names.

Others looked puzzled.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Everyone searched for the line that would determine the next chapter of their professional life.

I searched for one department.

ITX.

I found my name.

Then I looked at the department beside it.

It wasn't ITX.

For a moment, I thought I had misread the list.

I checked again.

And then once more.

The result didn't change.

I had been posted elsewhere.

I stood there for several minutes trying to make sense of it.

I had spent four years studying Computer Science.

I had travelled halfway across the country to begin my career.

Somewhere between college and BHEL, I had imagined countless versions of my future.

None of them had begun in a department unrelated to the field I had chosen.

Most people would probably have accepted the decision and moved on.

After all, I was only an Engineer Trainee.

Who was I to question an official posting?

But something inside me refused to let it go.

This wasn't about convenience.

It wasn't about prestige.

It was about becoming the kind of engineer I had worked so hard to be.

I walked to the General Manager's office and requested a meeting.

When I was called in, I explained my concern as calmly as I could.

"Sir, I completed my engineering in Computer Science."

"I came to BHEL hoping to build my career in that field."

"If I am assigned to a department where my qualification has little relevance, I don't believe I will be able to contribute my best."

There was a brief silence.

Then I said the one sentence I hadn't planned in advance.

"If this posting cannot be changed..."

"...I would rather resign."

Even as the words left my mouth, I surprised myself.

I wasn't trying to be dramatic.

I wasn't issuing an ultimatum.

I simply knew, with complete clarity, that this was the one compromise I couldn't make.

Some decisions shape the rest of your life.

Even at twenty-three, I sensed this was one of them.

The room grew quiet.

An Engineer Trainee offering to resign over a departmental posting was, understandably, not an everyday occurrence.

Questions were asked.

Conversations followed.

I was asked to wait.

Eventually, the decision was reconsidered.

A short while later, I received the news I had hoped for.

My posting had been changed.

I would be joining ITX.

As I walked out of the office, I didn't feel victorious.

I felt relieved.

Not because I had won an argument.

Because I had protected the future I had imagined for myself years earlier while sitting in a college classroom in Chennai.

At that moment, I had no idea where a career in technology would eventually take me.

I only knew I had taken the first step in the right direction.

The Computer Room

Walking into ITX for the first time felt like reaching a destination I had already fought for.

After the uncertainty surrounding my departmental posting, simply seeing the letters ITX outside the office brought a quiet sense of satisfaction. Whatever lay ahead, I knew I was finally where I wanted to be.

I also carried a head full of expectations.

After four years of studying Computer Science, I imagined entering a room filled with impressive computers, modern workstations and the latest software. In my mind, this was where the future lived.

The future, however, looked surprisingly ordinary.

Instead of rows of computers, the room was lined with monochrome terminals.

Each workstation had little more than a keyboard and a screen displaying green characters on a dark background. There were no CPUs under the desks, no familiar operating systems and nothing that resembled the computer labs I had grown used to during engineering.

For a moment, I wondered whether I had walked into the wrong department.

One of the senior engineers noticed my puzzled expression.

Smiling, he explained that these weren't computers in the conventional sense.

They were terminals connected to a central system housed in another room.

The applications we developed ran on an Ingres database using a programming language called 4GL, technologies I had never encountered before. Even the operating system felt unfamiliar, though some of its commands reminded me of UNIX.

It was my first lesson in professional software development.

College had taught me programming.

Industry was about to teach me systems.

The terminals had their own personalities.

Every now and then, one would simply stop responding.

Nobody panicked.

Nobody switched it off and on again.

Instead, the engineer using that terminal would walk into the adjacent computer room, tell the supervisor the terminal number and wait while the connection was reset from the central machine.

A few moments later, work would continue as though nothing had happened.

It seemed perfectly normal to everyone else.

I quickly learned that it would become perfectly normal to me as well.

Another surprise awaited me.

I had assumed this environment existed because I was still an Engineer Trainee.

It didn't.

The senior engineers sitting around me used exactly the same terminals.

This wasn't temporary training equipment.

This was the technology that powered one of BHEL's largest manufacturing units.

For the first time, I realized that the world outside college was very different from the one described in textbooks.

Years later, I would have the privilege of watching this department transform.

The green-screen terminals gradually disappeared.

Ingres gave way to Oracle.

New programming languages replaced 4GL.

Desktop computers arrived on every desk, eventually followed by technologies that would reshape the software industry itself.

Looking back now, I feel fortunate to have witnessed that entire evolution from the inside.

But on that first day, none of that future was visible.

There was only a terminal.

A keyboard.

A curious young engineer.

And an entirely new world waiting to be understood.

I had finally reached ITX.

It wasn't the future I had imagined.

As it turned out...

it was the beginning of a future I could never have imagined.

The People Behind the Terminals

A workplace slowly reveals itself.

Not through organization charts or job titles.

But through the people who occupy it every day.

Within a few weeks, the green terminals had become less intimidating. I no longer had to think twice before logging in, navigating the system or finding my way around the office. What remained unfamiliar were the countless small things that never appear in any training manual.

Fortunately, I wasn't expected to learn them alone.

The programming section of ITX occupied a long hall with rows of terminals arranged neatly along both walls and in two long rows through the middle of the room. A line of storage cupboards separated

the central workstations, creating two narrow aisles where engineers spent most of their day staring at green screens filled with code.

It wasn't a modern open office by today's standards.

But it had a rhythm of its own.

By the end of my first month, I could have walked through that room with my eyes closed.

I still remember exactly where I sat.

A few seats ahead of the rear of the hall.

Behind me sat my batchmate, Bhaskar Joshi.

Behind him was Meera Sharma Madam, the manager I reported to.

Directly in front of me sat Madhavi Bhagat, who had joined BHEL about a year before me.

To my left was another team headed by Sunita Sharma Madam, with Uday Mehta, one of the senior engineers, working alongside her.

Looking back, it amazes me that after more than twenty-five years I can still picture that seating arrangement more clearly than many places I visited only last week.

Memory has its own priorities.

Although we all belonged to ITX, the work was divided into smaller teams.

Each manager looked after software for a specific functional area within BHEL.

Meera Madam's team was responsible for Material Management.

Other teams developed and maintained applications for Stores, Payroll and several other business functions that kept a factory employing thousands of people running every day.

Software wasn't something that existed separately from the organization.

It quietly supported almost every department without most people ever noticing.

As trainees, we were gradually introduced to that responsibility.

My first assignments came under Meera Madam's guidance.

They were small enhancements and programs related to Material Management for the shop floor.

There were no revolutionary algorithms waiting for me.

No glamorous projects.

Instead, I learned something far more valuable.

How software solved real problems for real people.

Every program we wrote eventually found its way to someone on the shop floor or in an office who depended on it to do their work.

For the first time, programming had consequences beyond examination marks.

Like every new engineer, I had questions.

Many of them.

UNIX commands that made little sense.

Ingres queries that refused to work.

4GL programs that behaved differently from what I expected.

Whenever I got stuck, Madhavi Bhagat was often the first person I turned to.

Sometimes she would explain a command.

Sometimes she would quietly point out a mistake I had overlooked.

Sometimes she simply showed me a better way to think about the problem.

What I remember most, however, wasn't the answer.

It was the willingness to help.

Nobody ever made me feel embarrassed for asking.

Looking back, I realize that patience is one of the greatest gifts an experienced engineer can offer a newcomer.

I was fortunate to receive it generously.

Among the trainees posted to ITX with me were Bhaskar Joshi and Sameer Khatri.

Bhaskar and I found ourselves drawn towards software development, while Sameer naturally gravitated towards hardware and infrastructure.

No one forced us down a particular path.

Even within the same department, there was room to discover where our interests and strengths lay.

It was an early lesson that careers are shaped as much by curiosity as by assignments.

Twice each day, before lunch and again in the afternoon, work paused for tea.

At the rear of the hall stood a small seating area with a well-used sofa that somehow managed to accommodate whoever arrived first.

In those days, BHEL supplied tea and snacks through the factory canteen for just a few paise.

Later, our little corner evolved into an informal pantry, stocked with tea, sugar and biscuits, Our office attendant, Ramesh Bhaiya, somehow

knew exactly whose cup needed less sugar and who preferred stronger tea. The tea itself was ordinary.

The conversations never were.

Managers, senior engineers and trainees gathered together to exchange stories about users, unexpected software bugs, amusing incidents from the factory and the occasional misunderstanding that somehow became much funnier after it had been resolved.

For half an hour each day, designations quietly disappeared.

We were simply colleagues sharing tea.

Those conversations built a team far more effectively than any formal meeting ever could.

When I think back to ITX today, I certainly remember the green terminals.

I remember Ingres.

I remember 4GL.

But those aren't the memories that stayed with me.

The memories that endured belong to the people sitting behind those terminals.

They taught me that software is never built by machines alone.

It is built by patient mentors, curious newcomers, generous colleagues and countless conversations shared over cups of tea.

That was the real education I received in ITX.

The green terminals disappeared. The databases evolved. Programming languages came and went. Yet, after more than twenty-five years, I can still close my eyes and see exactly where everyone sat. Perhaps that is because we never truly remember workplaces for

the technology they used. We remember them for the people who quietly shaped the person we became.

Just Another Trainee

Some mornings begin like every other day.

Until someone walks through the door.

By then, I had settled comfortably into the rhythm of ITX. The green terminals no longer intimidated me, my programs were beginning to make sense, and every day brought a new problem to solve. Life had found a comfortable routine.

It was just another morning.

Or so I thought.

I was absorbed in my work when movement near the entrance caught my attention.

I looked up.

For a brief moment, I simply stared.

Standing near Meera Sharma Madam's desk was a familiar face.

It took me a few seconds to understand why she seemed so familiar.

Then it came back to me.

She was the same young woman I had noticed during my journey from Delhi to Haridwar several months earlier.

Of all the people I expected to see inside ITX that morning, she was certainly not one of them.

She looked different from the hurried traveller I remembered.

She was dressed in a simple salwar kameez, as she almost always seemed to be, with an effortless sense of colour that made even the simplest combinations look elegant.

What caught my attention even more, however, was her expression.

She appeared unusually quiet.

Almost nervous.

The reason became clear within moments.

She had earlier reported to ITX for her final-year project but had returned to her hometown without informing anyone.

When Pragati returned to Haridwar after her brief visit home, she walked into ITX carrying far more anxiety than luggage.

She had left without informing Meera Madam properly.

By the time she returned, she already knew what awaited her.

The moment she reported back, Meera Madam gave her the scolding she had been expecting.

It wasn't pleasant.

But it was deserved.

For the past several days, Pragati had imagined that conversation many times. The scolding itself wasn't the difficult part. The uncertainty was.

When it was over, she apologised.

Meera Madam accepted the apology.

Just like that, the tension disappeared.

The matter was closed.

More importantly, she was given a project.

That, more than anything else, brought relief.

A few minutes later, Meera Madam introduced her to me.

“Ravi will help you with the project.”

Pragati was pursuing an integrated Master’s degree in Mathematics with Computer Science and had joined BHEL to complete her final-year project.

“The project is in Material Management,” Meera Madam explained. “Help her whenever your work permits.”

I nodded.

“Sure, Madam.”

It sounded like an ordinary request.

At the time, that’s exactly what I believed it to be.

No mysterious feeling that destiny had entered the room.

She was simply another trainee who had joined our department.

From my side, I remember a quiet, polite young woman who had just returned after creating a little trouble for herself.

From her side, years later, she would confess that she barely remembered me at all.

She was simply relieved that Meera Madam had forgiven her.

If she remembered anything about me, it was something I had never thought about.

I spoke fluent Hindi.

Coming from Chennai, that had surprised her.

Unlike the engineers working inside ITX, project trainees weren’t allotted seats in our programming hall.

Pragati had been given a desk in another room.

Later that day, after finishing the work I had on hand, I walked over to introduce myself.

“Do you need any help?” I asked.

She smiled politely.

Relief briefly replaced the uncertainty I had noticed earlier that morning.

Over the next few weeks, helping with her project gradually became part of my daily routine.

Her strength was mathematics.

Programming, however, was something she approached with considerably less confidence.

Whenever time permitted, I explained the application, discussed the project requirements, helped her understand the code and answered whatever questions she had.

Sometimes the conversations lasted only a few minutes.

Sometimes they stretched much longer than either of us had planned.

My own assignments always came first.

Her project came whenever there was time.

It was a simple arrangement that suited both of us.

If someone had asked me then whether this young woman would one day become one of the most important people in my life, I would probably have laughed at the idea.

At that moment, she was simply another student trying to complete a project.

And I was simply another young engineer trying to do his job well.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Life, however, has a remarkable way of beginning its biggest stories in the most ordinary moments.

Looking back, what I remember most is not our first conversation but the feeling of recognition. Some meetings arrive with great fanfare. Others slip quietly into our lives, disguised as routine. This was one of those.

Chapter 6 - Growing Beyond Work

The Question I couldn't keep to Myself

Looking back today, I still struggle to explain what possessed me.

We had known each other only for a short time.

She had recently joined our project after returning from home. We spoke mostly about work. Occasionally there would be a casual conversation, but nothing that would have suggested what was about to come out of my mouth.

There was no grand plan.

No weeks of rehearsing.

No list of reasons.

One ordinary day inside ITX, while we were talking, I heard myself asking the question before I had fully thought it through.

“Will you marry me?”

Even now, more than twenty-five years later, I cannot remember what sequence of thoughts led me there.

Perhaps there wasn't one.

At twenty-four, I had a habit of acting first and analysing later.

It had helped me professionally. Whenever someone offered me a difficult project, curiosity usually answered before caution had a chance.

Apparently, the same instinct extended beyond engineering.

The moment the words left my mouth, I realised there was nothing I could do to take them back.

She looked completely surprised.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Who wouldn't have been?

We hardly knew each other.

There had been no long courtship, no carefully constructed romance and certainly no expectation that a conversation about work would suddenly turn into a marriage proposal.

I don't remember trying to explain myself.

I don't remember making an emotional speech.

The question had been asked.

It now belonged to both of us. Surprisingly her reaction was different. She left without saying a word.

A few days later, she went home.

And I was left alone with my own thoughts.

For the first time since joining BHEL, I found myself replaying a conversation over and over again, wondering whether I had just made the biggest mistake of my life.

Had I frightened her?

Had I embarrassed her?

Had I destroyed what could have been a perfectly good friendship before it had even begun?

There were no mobile phones then.

No messages.

No quick way to ask what she was thinking.

Only silence.

And silence has a remarkable ability to manufacture answers that reality never intended.

Looking back now, people sometimes ask when our love story began.

They expect a dramatic moment.

A perfect beginning.

The truth is far less impressive.

It began with a young engineer who spoke before he thought.

Everything that truly mattered came afterwards.

As If Nothing Happened

The few days that Pragati was away were probably no different from any other week at ITX.

Projects continued.

Meetings happened.

People came and went.

Work moved forward exactly as it always had.

Only my mind refused to move on.

The more I replayed our last conversation, the more convinced I became that I had made a complete fool of myself.

What had possessed me to ask a girl I barely knew whether she would marry me?

The question itself no longer seemed surprising.

My timing did.

Every possible outcome seemed equally disastrous.

Perhaps she would refuse to work with me.

Perhaps she would ask to be assigned to someone else.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Perhaps she would simply avoid me.

Without mobile phones or instant messages, there was nothing to do except wait.

And wait I did.

The morning she returned, I noticed her almost immediately.

Not because she entered dramatically.

Not because everyone turned to look.

Simply because I had been looking towards the entrance every few minutes without even realising it.

She walked in carrying a few files, greeted everyone with her usual smile and settled into her seat.

A few moments later, she looked towards me.

“Good morning.”

“Good morning.”

Nothing more.

No hesitation.

No awkwardness.

No uncomfortable silence.

Just two individuals beginning another working day.

A little later she walked over to my desk with a question about the project.

We discussed it exactly as we had before she left.

Within minutes we were debating different approaches, sketching ideas on paper and arguing over technical details as though nothing unusual had happened.

By lunchtime, the burden I had carried for days had quietly disappeared.

Life had returned to normal.

More importantly...

So had we.

Looking back now, I realise how easy it would have been for our story to end before it had even begun.

One awkward conversation was all it would have taken.

Instead, Pragati chose something far wiser than either of us probably understood at the time.

She chose normal.

She didn't pretend my question had never been asked.

Neither did she allow it to become the centre of every conversation that followed.

She simply continued being herself.

And without either of us noticing, our friendship quietly resumed its journey.

The weeks that followed brought nothing extraordinary.

I would help her with work.

Sometimes we stayed back discussing projects.

Sometimes I dropped her back to the hostel on my motorcycle.

Some evenings we talked longer than either of us intended.

None of those moments announced themselves as important.

They were simply becoming part of everyday life.

People often ask when our relationship truly began.

Many assume it was the day I proposed.

I don't think so.

If I had to choose the day our story really began, I would choose this one.

The day she returned.

The day she smiled.

The day we spoke about work.

The day we quietly carried on.

Because sometimes the biggest answer in life isn't spoken.

It's lived.

When Haridwar Became Home

Nobody tells you when a new city stops feeling new.

It doesn't happen on a particular morning.

There isn't a welcome ceremony.

One day you simply realise that you no longer need to think before turning at familiar streets, that shopkeepers have stopped looking at you as a stranger, and that the place you once called temporary has quietly become part of your life.

Haridwar had reached that point for me.

The nervousness of my first few weeks had disappeared. I knew the route from the hostel to ITX without thinking. The security guards recognised us. Tea breaks had become part of the day's rhythm, and familiar faces greeted one another long before the office officially came to life.

Work no longer felt overwhelming.

There was still plenty to learn, and every week brought something new, but I had stopped measuring my days by how many mistakes I made. Instead, I began measuring them by how much I understood compared to the previous week.

Outside work, life had found its own rhythm.

The training institute was no longer just a place where Pragati studied. It had become one of the places I visited without needing a reason. Some evenings we met for tea. On other days we simply walked through the familiar roads around the campus, talking about whatever came to mind.

There were no profound conversations.

We spoke about our families.

We compared life in Chennai and Haridwar.

We laughed about small incidents at work and at the institute.

Sometimes we discussed our dreams.

Sometimes we spent an hour together and, looking back today, I cannot remember a single topic we discussed.

What I remember is how effortless those conversations had become.

Friendship has a curious way of changing.

In the beginning, every meeting feels special because it is unexpected.

Later, the meetings become so natural that they stop standing out individually.

They simply become part of life.

That was what had happened to us.

Looking back now, I cannot identify the day when Pragati became an important part of my everyday routine.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

There was no defining conversation.

No dramatic moment.

No promise of a future together.

One ordinary day simply flowed into another until her presence no longer felt like an interruption to my life. It felt like it had always belonged there.

Perhaps that is how the strongest relationships begin.

Not with fireworks.

Not with grand declarations.

But with ordinary days that quietly become unforgettable only after they have passed.

Without realising it, I had started thinking of Haridwar as home.

Not because I had lived there for long.

But because home is rarely defined by a place.

More often, it is defined by the people who slowly become part of your everyday life.

Small Adventures

Growing up, I had imagined that friendships were built around extraordinary moments. Long journeys, unforgettable conversations or dramatic incidents that remained etched in memory forever.

Life, I would later discover, worked very differently.

Most friendships are built one ordinary day at a time.

By then, Haridwar had begun to feel familiar. The roads no longer seemed new, the markets had become recognisable and even the changing weather had settled into a rhythm. Office work occupied my

weekdays while Pragati immersed herself in completing the project work for her M.Sc. in Mathematics with Computer Science.

Whenever time permitted, we found reasons to meet.

There was never a plan to create memories.

We simply lived those days.

Sometimes we watched a movie.

Sometimes we rode around Haridwar on my motorcycle without any particular destination in mind. The journey itself was enough.

Some evenings ended over tea, where conversations wandered from studies and work to family, books and the different worlds we had grown up in.

Occasionally, a perfectly ordinary afternoon stretched into hours without either of us noticing.

Looking back now, I struggle to remember the exact sequence of those days.

I cannot always remember which movie we watched first.

Or which ride came before another.

Or what we spoke about on every evening walk.

Memory has quietly erased those details.

What it has preserved instead is a feeling.

The comfort of never having to impress each other.

The ease of conversation.

The silence that never felt uncomfortable.

We never carried this friendship into the workplace.

Inside BHEL, I remained another young engineer.

She remained a student completing her project.

After office hours, life resumed where it had paused.

Years later, many of my colleagues would tell me they had never known Pragati and I had even known each other before our marriage.

I would simply smile.

Perhaps that was exactly how we had wanted it.

Those months in Haridwar were never about making promises.

They were about discovering that the simplest moments often become the ones we remember the longest.

At the time, neither of us realised that these ordinary days were quietly becoming memories.

A Visitor from Mainpuri

Until then, Pragati and I had spoken often about our families.

She knew about my parents in Chennai, and I knew that her father was serving as a General Manager in an industrial organisation in Mainpuri. He was nearing retirement after a long career, although neither of us knew then that he would continue living in Mainpuri for a few more years even after retiring.

One day, Pragati told me that her father would be visiting Haridwar and wanted to meet me.

It seemed like an ordinary request.

Only years later did I realise how important that afternoon really was.

They arrived together at my hostel.

I still remember him dressed formally, carrying himself with the quiet confidence of someone who had spent decades leading people and making decisions.

After we exchanged greetings, he looked at Pragati and gently asked her to wait outside for a while.

He wanted to speak with me alone.

For a brief moment, I wasn't quite sure what to expect.

Instead, what followed was one of the most courteous conversations I can remember.

He asked where I came from.

He asked about my family.

He wanted to know about my work and my future in BHEL.

Somewhere during the conversation, he realised that I wasn't another student temporarily associated with the project work in Haridwar.

I had joined BHEL as a permanent engineer and was beginning my career there.

His questions were never intrusive.

Looking back now, I don't think he was trying to judge me.

He was simply doing what any caring father would do.

His daughter had travelled far from home to complete her M.Sc. project, and somewhere during those months she had become friends with a young engineer.

He wanted to know who that young man was.

I wish I could remember every question he asked that afternoon.

I can't.

Memory has quietly taken away the details.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

What remains is the feeling.

The conversation was respectful.

Measured.

Calm.

Exactly as one would expect from a gentleman of his generation.

After some time, Pragati came back inside.

We exchanged a few more pleasantries before they prepared to leave.

As we walked towards the hostel entrance, he smiled politely and said something very simple.

“I’ll think it over and get back.”

There was nothing more.

No promises.

No decisions.

No dramatic conclusion.

At the time, it felt like an ordinary goodbye.

Today, I understand it differently.

That afternoon wasn’t about seeking permission.

It wasn’t about fixing a marriage.

It was simply the first meeting between two families that didn’t yet know they would one day become one.

Chapter 7 - The Roads That Part

Roads That Part

A little while after our meeting in the hostel, it was time for Pragati to leave Haridwar.

Her project work for the M.Sc. programme had come to an end.

The reason that had brought her to Haridwar had quietly fulfilled its purpose.

Her father had come to take her home.

Outside the hostel stood a white Bolero-like government vehicle, the kind that was a familiar sight in Uttar Pradesh during those days. It looked practical rather than elegant, built for long journeys across highways and small towns.

We walked together towards the hostel entrance.

There were no emotional speeches.

No dramatic promises.

Just a simple goodbye.

I watched as they got into the vehicle.

A few moments later, it disappeared beyond the hostel gate.

And just like that, the routine that had quietly become part of my life came to an end.

The evenings suddenly became quieter.

There was an emptiness that I hadn't expected.

What surprised me even more was how little certainty I had about what would happen next.

I didn't know where Mainpuri was.

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I had never been there.

All I had was a landline telephone number.

There were no mobile phones.

No instant messages.

No social media.

If I wanted to speak with Pragati, I would walk to the nearby STD booth and dial that familiar number.

Sometimes our conversations would continue for hours.

Yet, strangely, we never spent those hours talking about marriage or planning a future together.

We simply talked.

About work.

About family.

About everyday life.

Looking back today, I find that remarkable.

Two young people stayed connected not because they had a plan, but because they genuinely enjoyed talking to each other.

When she left Haridwar, I had no idea where our friendship would lead.

In fact, I wasn't even sure there would be another chapter.

It felt less like the beginning of a long journey and more like the closing of one.

At the time, it was simply goodbye.

Part III - Becoming a Professional

Chapter 8 - Building a Career

A New Challenge

By the time I had spent a couple of years in ITX, work had settled into a comfortable rhythm. Every morning I parked my silver Hero Honda Splendor outside the administrative building, signed the attendance register, and walked into an office that had become familiar. The uncertainty of my trainee days had quietly disappeared. I knew the people, understood the systems, and had become comfortable taking up software assignments that came my way.

Every project taught me something new. I wasn't just learning programming anymore; I was beginning to understand how software could solve real business problems inside a large engineering organization.

One day, I was asked to meet Mr. Rajiv Malhotra, the Assistant General Manager.

I don't remember whether the message came through a phone call to my desk or was delivered by a peon. I only remember walking into his office and finding Mr. Sanjay Mehta from the Quality Department already waiting there.

After a brief introduction, Mr. Mehta opened a folder and began explaining a new project.

The Quality Department had developed a process called *Quality Through Measurement*. It depended on a collection of Microsoft Excel spreadsheets linked together through multiple levels of calculations. The system had served them well, but it had become increasingly difficult to maintain. They wanted the entire process converted into a software application.

I understood very little of what he was explaining.

The calculations were unfamiliar.

The business terminology was unfamiliar.

Even the overall process was new to me.

But strangely, none of that worried me.

Over the previous months I had immersed myself in Java, JSP and Servlets. Learning those technologies had quietly changed the way I looked at problems. I might not understand every business process on the first day, but I had developed confidence that software could be built to solve them.

When the explanation was over, Mr. Malhotra looked at me.

“Would you be interested in taking up this project?”

There was no hesitation.

“Yes, sir.”

I didn’t ask how difficult it was.

I didn’t ask how long it would take.

I didn’t ask whether anyone else had attempted it before.

To me, it was simply another software project.

The meeting ended, and I returned to my desk.

There was no excitement.

No anxiety.

No feeling that I had just accepted something significant.

It was simply another day at work.

Only much later did I learn that the project carried far greater importance than I had understood that morning. What had appeared

to be an ordinary assignment would become one of the defining experiences of my early professional life.

Life rarely announces its turning points.

Sometimes they arrive quietly, disguised as nothing more than another day at work.

Winning Hearts and Minds

When I accepted the project, I imagined most of my time would be spent writing software.

I couldn't have been more wrong.

Before a single line of code could be written, we had to understand how the Quality Through Measurement process actually worked. That meant spending time with the people who performed these activities every day. Mr. Sanjay Mehta took me along as we met supervisors and engineers from one department after another across the factory.

Every department had its own way of maintaining records. Large registers sat on tables, loose sheets were tucked between files and, in some places, carefully maintained Excel spreadsheets had become part of the daily routine. Years of experience lived in these documents and in the minds of the people who maintained them.

As the proposed software system was explained, the reaction was often the same.

"We already do this work every day."

"Now you want us to enter everything into a computer as well?"

"Who has time for that?"

At first, I didn't understand the resistance.

From my perspective, the software would make their work easier. It would automate calculations, eliminate repetitive effort and produce reports much faster than the existing spreadsheets. The benefits seemed obvious.

But they saw something entirely different.

To them, the software represented additional work at the end of an already demanding day. They were responsible for production targets, inspections, documentation and countless activities on the shop floor. Data entry felt like one more responsibility added to an already full schedule.

That was when I began to appreciate the role Mr. Mehta was playing. He never dismissed their concerns.

He patiently explained why the information mattered, how the system would be used and what benefits it would eventually bring. Every question was answered. Every objection was discussed. Sometimes the same explanation had to be repeated several times to different groups.

I mostly listened.

Whenever technical questions came up about the proposed software, I would explain how we intended to capture the information or how a particular calculation would work. At other times, I simply observed the conversations unfold.

Those meetings taught me something that no programming book ever had.

People rarely resist technology.

They resist change.

Looking back, I realize that Mr. Mehta was doing far more than introducing a software application. He was patiently building

confidence across departments, one conversation at a time. Without that effort, even the best software would have remained unused.

Only after those discussions began to create confidence did the real work of building the application truly begin.

Until then, I had believed software projects started with coding.

This project quietly taught me that they actually begin with people.

Recognition

The months that followed were some of the busiest I had experienced since joining BHEL.

The software gradually took shape as each discussion uncovered another business rule or another exception that had quietly existed inside the old spreadsheets. What had first appeared to be a programming assignment slowly became an exercise in understanding how quality was measured across a large manufacturing organization.

The application evolved one module at a time.

We tested it, refined it and tested it again.

Whenever a problem surfaced during implementation, we returned to the users, understood their concerns and made the necessary improvements. As more departments began using the system, confidence slowly replaced hesitation. The conversations gradually changed from, “Why should we use it?” to, “Can the system also do this?”

Watching that change was deeply satisfying.

Looking back, I realize that the project succeeded because it was never treated as an IT project alone. It became a collaborative effort between the Quality Department, ITX and the many people across the factory who were willing to adapt their daily routines to make it work.

As the software settled into everyday use, it became evident that the project had delivered benefits well beyond what we had originally expected. Manual calculations gave way to a standardized system, quality reporting became faster and more consistent, and over time the organization realized substantial financial savings.

For me, however, the greatest reward had already arrived.

Somewhere during the project, without consciously noticing it, I had stopped thinking like a trainee and had begun thinking like an engineer.

Around the same time, my family came to Haridwar.

My father, mother, grandmother and sister had all travelled from Chennai to spend a few weeks with me. Until then, they had known my life only through letters and occasional telephone calls. Now they were finally seeing the place that had become my home.

Those weeks remain among my happiest memories of Haridwar.

One morning we decided to drive to Rishikesh.

By then I owned a second-hand FIAT Padmini. It wasn't a new car and certainly wasn't luxurious, but it was the first car I had purchased with my own earnings.

We somehow managed to fit everyone inside.

My father sat beside me while my mother, grandmother and sister settled into the back seat. Before we left, my mother packed enough homemade food for everyone. She never believed a family outing was complete without carrying food from home.

Instead of taking the usual highway, we drove through the Chilla forest route.

The road wound quietly through dense greenery with occasional glimpses of the Ganga flowing beside us. There was no hurry to reach

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our destination. We stopped midway, found a pleasant spot near the river and unpacked the food my mother had prepared.

Looking back, I don't remember what we ate.

I only remember how happy everyone looked.

After lunch we continued towards Rishikesh.

As soon as my grandmother saw the Ganga, she decided she wanted to take a dip.

The problem was that she hadn't brought a change of clothes.

That made no difference to her.

Faith had already made the decision.

The rest of us could only smile as she carefully stepped into the cold waters of the Ganga, completely unconcerned about the practical inconvenience that would follow.

That moment captured her perfectly.

We spent the rest of the day visiting a few ashrams, strolling across Lakshman Jhula and simply enjoying being together. Before returning to Haridwar, we stopped at Chotiwalla for a leisurely meal, as almost every visitor to Rishikesh did in those days.

By evening we were back home.

At the time, it felt like nothing more than an ordinary family outing.

Years later, I realized it had been one of those rare days when four generations of our family travelled together.

The old FIAT Padmini is long gone.

The roads have changed.

Even Rishikesh has changed.

But whenever I think about that drive through Chilla, I don't remember the destination.

I remember the people who travelled with me.

A few weeks later, another piece of news quietly spread through our department.

Our Quality Through Measurement project had been nominated for one of BHEL's annual Excellence Awards.

Even the nomination felt like recognition.

Among the many projects executed across different BHEL units, ours had been selected to represent Haridwar. It was an acknowledgement that the work had created value far beyond our own department.

I didn't spend much time thinking about awards.

The greatest satisfaction had already come from seeing the software become part of everyday life inside the factory and from sharing one of the happiest periods of my Haridwar years with the people who mattered most to me.

Whatever happened next would simply be a bonus.

A Proud Day

The official communication arrived a few weeks before the ceremony.

Our Quality Through Measurement project had been selected for BHEL's Excellence Award, and I had been asked to represent the project at the award function in New Delhi.

For someone who had joined BHEL only a few years earlier as a young engineer, it felt surreal.

The project had started with a simple question from Rajiv Malhotra. It had grown into months of learning, discussions with factory

departments, countless revisions and patient implementation led by Sanjay Mehta. Now it had become something much larger than any of us had imagined.

My mother was visiting Haridwar during that period.

She insisted on accompanying me to Delhi.

Looking back, I think she was even happier than I was.

To her, it wasn't about software or business improvements. It was about seeing her son being recognized for his work.

We travelled together to Delhi.

I remember carefully packing my suit, polishing my shoes and wondering what the ceremony would be like. Until then, awards belonged to other people. This was the first time I was travelling to receive one myself.

The auditorium was filled with teams from BHEL units across the country. Listening to the different projects made me appreciate the sheer scale of the organization and the quiet work happening in factories spread across India.

When our project was announced, I walked to the stage with mixed emotions.

Pride.

Gratitude.

Disbelief.

As I accepted the award, one thought stayed with me.

Although I was standing on the stage, this recognition belonged to many people.

Rajiv Malhotra had trusted me with the opportunity.

Sanjay Mehta had patiently convinced people across departments to embrace a new way of working.

The factory teams had accepted the system and made it part of their daily work.

Without them, there would have been no award.

Holding the trophy in my hands, I realized that recognition brings something more valuable than applause.

It brings responsibility.

People begin to expect more from you.

And you begin to expect more from yourself.

After the ceremony, the first thing I did was call my father in Chennai.

A few months earlier, I had arranged Reliance mobile connections for my parents, and for the first time sharing an important moment no longer required searching for an STD booth or waiting until I returned home.

“Appa...”

“We received the award.”

There was a brief silence before he congratulated me.

My father was never expressive with words.

He didn’t have to be.

I could hear the pride in his voice.

As my mother and I left the venue that evening, I realized something.

The trophy would eventually find a place on a shelf.

The memory of sharing that day with my mother, and hearing my father’s quiet happiness over the phone, would stay with me much longer.

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That was the real award.

Chapter 9 - Looking Beyond Work

Life Goes On

The Excellence Award ceremony had become a cherished memory. The new Santro had already found its place in our lives, and work at ITX had settled into a comfortable rhythm. Projects moved steadily, familiar faces filled the corridors each morning, and the excitement surrounding the award had gradually given way to the routines of everyday life.

My mother had now been with me in Haridwar for over six months. What had begun as a temporary visit after I bought the car had quietly become part of our daily lives. She knew the neighbours, had discovered her favourite vegetable vendors, and had even begun speaking a few words of Hindi with surprising confidence. The little BHEL quarter no longer felt like bachelor accommodation. It had become a home.

Then one afternoon, my mobile phone rang.

It was my sister calling from Chennai.

My father's health had become a concern again.

Ever since his bypass surgery nearly a decade earlier, there had been occasional episodes when his heart rate would slow down, leaving him weak and unable to manage everyday activities comfortably. This was one such occasion. It wasn't serious enough to require hospitalization, but it was enough for all of us to know that he shouldn't be left alone.

My sister was still studying and could only do so much. My mother immediately knew what had to be done.

"I should go back," she said quietly.

I briefly considered taking leave and travelling with her to Chennai, but when I spoke to my father, he dismissed the idea in his usual reassuring manner.

“We’ll manage,” he said. “You don’t need to take leave.”

That was typical of him. Even when he needed help, his first concern was that I shouldn’t disrupt my work.

My mother had grown fond of Haridwar. She enjoyed the peaceful township, had become familiar with the neighbourhood and was beginning to feel at home there. Leaving wasn’t easy, but some responsibilities leave little room for choice. Duty had called, and she answered without hesitation.

It was the middle of January, and North India was covered in its familiar winter fog.

She packed only a small bag with a few clothes and enough woollens for the journey to Delhi. Beyond that, the Tamil Nadu Express would carry her south through warmer weather.

My first instinct was to drive her to Delhi in the Santro, but the visibility outside was frighteningly poor. Mother refused to let me take the risk.

Instead, we boarded a UPSRTC bus at the Haridwar bus stand.

The bus moved cautiously through the dense fog. At times, I could barely make out the road ahead from my window seat. It amazed me how confidently the driver navigated conditions that looked impossible to everyone else. Years of experience had taught them to drive through winters that visitors could scarcely imagine.

By late afternoon we reached Delhi’s Inter State Bus Terminal. From there we took an auto-rickshaw to New Delhi Railway Station. Her train, the Tamil Nadu Express, was scheduled to leave around ten that

night, giving us several hours to sit together on the crowded platform, talking about ordinary things that neither of us would remember later.

When the boarding announcement came, the moment arrived sooner than I was prepared for.

She smiled, adjusted the end of her saree over her shoulder and reminded me to eat properly.

I smiled and promised I would.

As the train slowly pulled out of the station, I stood watching until the last coach disappeared into the darkness.

The journey back to Haridwar felt much longer than the one we had made together.

When I unlocked the door of my BHEL quarter, the silence was unmistakable. Nothing had changed inside the house, yet everything felt different. After more than six months, I was living alone once again.

Life, however, has a way of finding its rhythm.

A local lady continued to come each day to prepare my lunch and dinner. Work occupied most of my weekdays, and evenings were spent reading, relaxing or speaking with friends. Calls to Chennai became frequent. Mobile phones had made staying connected far easier than it had been only a few years earlier. Gradually, my father's health improved, and with every conversation there was a little less worry in my mother's voice.

Before long, work had reclaimed its usual place in my life.

Around the same time, during a casual conversation in the office, Sumit Bansal, one of our senior colleagues in ITX, asked Bhaskar Joshi and me whether we had ever considered pursuing higher studies while continuing to work.

He spoke about the M.S. Software Systems programme offered by BITS Pilani for working professionals. I had heard of BITS before, but never seriously considered studying there. An MBA had never really interested me, but a master's degree in software systems seemed like a natural extension of the work I was already doing.

The programme was designed specifically for professionals. It followed a distance-learning model with online coursework, assignments submitted electronically and semester examinations held every six months in Delhi. There were no classroom sessions requiring extended leave from work, and the fees were affordable enough for me to pay without seeking company sponsorship.

The more I thought about it, the more it seemed like the right decision.

Bhaskar and I completed the admission formalities and enrolled in the M.S. Software Systems programme at BITS Pilani.

At the time, it felt like a simple decision to continue learning alongside my career.

Looking back, it marked the beginning of another journey—one that would quietly shape the opportunities waiting for me in the years ahead.

Learning Never Stops

The laptop I had purchased with my Excellence Award prize money soon found a purpose that went far beyond office work. Every evening after returning from ITX, it transformed my dining table into a classroom.

For the next two years, I lived two parallel lives.

During the day, I was a software engineer working on projects at BHEL. By evening, I became a student once again.

Bhaskar Joshi and I had enrolled in the M.S. Software Systems programme offered by BITS Pilani for working professionals. The programme suited engineers like us who wanted to continue learning without leaving our jobs. It followed a distance-learning model with online coursework, assignments submitted electronically and semester examinations conducted every six months in Delhi.

I had never been interested in pursuing an MBA. Management did not excite me as much as technology did. Software engineering was where my curiosity lay, and the opportunity to earn a master's degree from an institution as respected as BITS Pilani felt like a natural progression.

Balancing work and studies, however, demanded discipline.

The office occupied most of the day. Evenings belonged to BITS.

After dinner, I would open my laptop, review course material, work through assignments and prepare for the upcoming examinations. There was no classroom to attend, no professor reminding us about deadlines and no classmates sitting beside us. Everything depended on our own commitment.

Living alone actually helped.

The BHEL quarter was quiet. There were few distractions. My evenings settled into a comfortable rhythm of reading, coding, writing assignments and preparing for examinations. It wasn't always easy after a full day at work, but I enjoyed learning. Every new subject seemed directly connected to the work we were doing in ITX, making the effort feel worthwhile.

Every six months, our routine changed.

Examination time meant another drive to Delhi.

More often than not, I was behind the wheel. I had always enjoyed driving, and the journey from Haridwar to Delhi had gradually

become familiar. We usually left early in the morning and reached Delhi by afternoon, giving ourselves enough time to settle down before the examinations began the following day.

Our examination centre was St. Francis School in Delhi.

Sumit Bansal's family made those trips considerably easier. His elderly mother welcomed us into her apartment with remarkable warmth. We usually stayed there overnight before the examinations. Breakfast was almost always at her home, while lunch and dinner were usually managed outside between revision sessions and examination schedules.

One memory from those visits still makes me smile.

Living alone in my BHEL quarter had simplified my needs to the bare essentials. My bathroom contained little more than a bar of soap and a bottle of shampoo. The first time I walked into the bathroom at Sumit's mother's apartment, I was genuinely surprised. Shelves were neatly lined with different soaps, shampoos, toothbrushes, face washes and toiletries that I had never really thought much about. It struck me how differently people lived. Looking back today, the memory seems amusing, but at that moment it was an unexpected glimpse into another household and another way of life.

The examinations themselves were anything but easy.

Many people assume that open-book examinations are simpler because the textbooks are available during the test. Our experience was exactly the opposite.

The books rarely contained ready-made answers. They merely served as references. Success depended on understanding concepts well enough to apply them under pressure. The questions demanded analysis rather than memorization, and the evaluation was uncompromising. Scoring good marks required genuine effort, and the

academic standards matched the reputation that BITS Pilani had built over decades.

Each semester brought two demanding days of examinations covering multiple subjects. By the time the final paper ended, we were mentally exhausted. The drive back to Haridwar always felt more relaxed. The discussions shifted from formulas and algorithms to whether we had interpreted a question correctly or forgotten an important point somewhere in the answer.

Then came the waiting.

Results arrived through email.

Opening those emails never became routine. There was always a mixture of curiosity and nervousness before clicking on the result. Every successful semester brought not only relief but also the satisfaction of knowing that the balance between work and study was actually possible.

Looking back, I realize that those two years taught me much more than software systems.

They reinforced the importance of discipline, consistency and lifelong learning. No manager asked us to enroll. No promotion depended on it. We pursued it simply because we believed that becoming a better engineer required continuous learning.

The degree remains one of the accomplishments I cherish most.

Not because it added another qualification after my name, but because it was earned one evening, one assignment and one examination at a time, while building a career that I was equally passionate about.

Those quiet evenings in my Haridwar quarter, with a laptop open on the dining table and tomorrow's office work waiting in the background, taught me a lesson that has stayed with me ever since.

Learning never truly ends. It simply finds new classrooms.

Chasing Sunsets

A few months after enrolling in the BITS programme, I received a phone call from one of my closest college friends, Pradeep.

He had an idea.

“Let’s do a road trip across Rajasthan.”

It didn’t take much convincing.

I had always enjoyed driving, and ever since buying the Santro, I had been looking for an excuse to take it on a long journey. Rajasthan sounded perfect. Neither of us had explored the state properly, and a week on the road seemed like exactly the kind of break we both needed.

When we discussed the trip over the phone, Pradeep casually mentioned that he had a driving licence and could share the driving responsibilities.

That sounded reassuring.

Driving over two thousand kilometres between two people felt entirely manageable.

There was another generous offer as well.

Pradeep insisted that he would sponsor the entire trip. Since he had recently returned from the United Kingdom, where he was working, he didn’t want me to worry about the expenses.

I happily agreed.

Only after he arrived in Haridwar did I discover the first surprise.

“I have a driving licence,” he admitted with an embarrassed smile, “but I’ve actually never driven.”

I looked at him for a moment before we both burst into laughter.

So much for sharing the driving.

The Santro and I would be doing all the work.

The route was simple.

Haridwar to Delhi.

Delhi to Jaipur.

Jaipur to Bikaner.

Bikaner to Jaisalmer.

Jaisalmer to Jodhpur through Barmer.

Jodhpur back to Jaipur.

Jaipur to Agra.

Every morning followed almost the same routine.

Wake up early.

Load our bags into the Santro.

Consult the road map.

Start driving.

Cover three hundred kilometres or more.

Check into an RTDC hotel.

Freshen up.

Rush out for sightseeing before sunset.

The next morning, repeat the entire cycle.

There were no smartphones, no GPS navigation and certainly no online hotel bookings. Paper maps, road signs and occasional

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conversations with strangers guided us across Rajasthan. Somehow, the journey felt more adventurous because of it.

Jaipur welcomed us with its grand forts and wide avenues. It was our first taste of Rajasthan's rich history and distinctive architecture. By the following afternoon we were already back on the highway, heading towards Bikaner.

One of the most unusual places we visited during the trip was the famous Karni Mata Temple at Deshnok.

Better known as the Rat Temple, it was unlike anything I had ever seen.

Thousands of rats moved freely throughout the temple while devotees walked among them with complete ease. The sight was astonishing at first, but after spending some time there, curiosity gradually replaced surprise. There was supposedly one white rat and seeing it was considered auspicious. But it wasn't that hard too, you just had to give some money to the local kids playing around and they effortlessly take you where you can see the white rat.

Rajasthan had already begun reminding us that every place carries traditions that make perfect sense to those who grow up with them.

From Bikaner we continued towards Jaisalmer.

That drive remains one of my favourites. On the way we passed through the famous Phokran where India successfully completed its nuclear test.

By the time we reached the city, evening was approaching rapidly.

Instead of checking into our hotel, we made an instant decision.

The luggage could wait.

The room could wait.

Sunset would not.

We drove straight to Sam Sand Dunes.

Standing there as the sun slowly disappeared over the Thar Desert remains one of the most beautiful memories of that journey. Years earlier, another unforgettable sunset had stayed with me at Kovalam. This one was entirely different. There was no sound of waves, no sea breeze and no endless blue horizon. Instead, there was silence, golden sand stretching in every direction and a sky that changed colours every few minutes until the desert was bathed in shades of orange and crimson.

It was one of those rare moments when neither of us felt the need to say anything. We returned with the satisfaction and had our dinner and retired for the day.

The following day was spent exploring Jaisalmer itself.

The magnificent fort rising above the city, Gadisar Lake, the nearby fossil park and a traditional Rajasthani village together painted a picture of a region that felt completely different from anywhere I had travelled before.

From there we continued to Jodhpur through Barmer, once again covering hundreds of kilometres before rewarding ourselves with another evening of exploring forts, lakes and bustling markets.

The journey itself became the destination.

Although Pradeep had promised to sponsor the entire holiday, we encountered an unexpected hiccup along the way. His overseas bank card simply refused to work at several places. Fortunately, I had my Citibank credit card with me, so I settled the expenses throughout the trip. True to his word, Pradeep reimbursed me in full after we returned. It never became an issue between us, and in many ways it reflected the trust we shared as friends.

Somewhere along those long highways, conversations naturally became more personal.

Pradeep shared the reason he had come to India.

His mother had recently arranged for him to meet a prospective bride. During their conversation, he had asked her a simple question.

“Why do you want to marry me?”

Without hesitation, she had replied that marrying him would allow her to settle in the United Kingdom.

The honesty of the answer had disappointed him deeply. He had declined the proposal and decided that a long road trip across Rajasthan was probably a better way to clear his mind before returning to work in the UK.

Listening to him, I realised he had trusted me with something deeply personal.

Perhaps that is why, for the first time, I found myself speaking openly about a part of my own life that very few people knew about.

I told him about Pragati.

For years, our relationship had remained a closely guarded secret. Outside our immediate families, almost no one knew about us. It wasn't something I discussed casually, but the endless highways of Rajasthan seemed to create the kind of conversations that ordinary days never did.

Pradeep listened quietly.

When I finished, he looked at me with a smile.

“How far is she from Agra?”

“Just a few hundred kilometres,” I replied.

He thought about it for only a moment.

“We’ve already come this far,” he said.

“Let’s go and meet her.”

The Surprise

A few years earlier, I had travelled all the way to Agra hoping to meet Pragati. For reasons beyond either of our control, the meeting never happened. In those days, before mobile phones became part of everyday life, there was no easy way to understand what had gone wrong. I had returned to Haridwar without seeing her, carrying nothing more than unanswered questions.

Perhaps that memory was one of the reasons I was determined not to let another opportunity slip away.

After completing our Rajasthan road trip, Pradeep and I reached Agra through Fatehpur Sikri. We spent the evening visiting the Taj Mahal, but my thoughts had already moved beyond Agra.

Somewhere a few hundred kilometres away was Mainpuri.

The last time I had spoken to Pragati over the phone, she had casually mentioned that she had started working as a teacher at a Christian mission school in Mainpuri. That was all I knew.

I knew the town.

I knew she worked at a school.

Nothing more.

The plan was to drive to Mainpuri that evening, stay somewhere for the night and reach her school before classes began the following morning.

As we left Agra after sunset and started asking for directions towards Mainpuri, the atmosphere slowly changed.

The roads became quieter. The villages grew smaller.

The people we encountered along the way made us increasingly uncomfortable. Some appeared intoxicated. Others casually carried double-barrel guns slung over their shoulders, something that was completely unfamiliar to us. This was rural Uttar Pradesh as it existed then, and as darkness settled around us, neither of us felt confident continuing the journey.

Without much discussion, we turned the Santro around.

Sometimes good judgment is simply knowing when not to continue.

We returned to Agra, checked into a hotel for the night and decided to start again before sunrise.

The next morning we left while the roads were still quiet.

As daylight slowly spread across the countryside, the landscape around us looked completely different from Haridwar. There were vast farmlands stretching into the distance, farmers beginning their day's work and villages waking up at an unhurried pace. Mainpuri felt peaceful in a way that contrasted sharply with Haridwar, where industry and pilgrimage shaped the rhythm of everyday life.

By around half past six we reached what we believed was Pragati's school.

Everything seemed to fit.

A Christian school.

Children had not yet arrived.

Teachers would be coming shortly.

Perfect.

We decided to wait outside the gate.

I even asked the security guard if a teacher named Pragati worked there, but he wasn't sure. We assumed he simply didn't know every member of the staff.

So we waited.

Gradually children began arriving.

Teachers walked in.

The morning bell rang.

The gates closed.

Classes began.

Pragati never arrived.

Only then did we discover what had happened.

There wasn't just one Christian school in Mainpuri.

There were two.

We had been waiting outside the wrong one.

Without wasting another minute, we rushed back to the car and drove across town to the second school.

This time we found the correct one.

Unfortunately, the school day had already begun.

Standing outside the gate once again, I wasn't sure what to do.

Then a thought occurred to me.

Instead of waiting outside hoping to catch a glimpse of her, why not simply ask?

I walked into the principal's office, introduced myself politely and explained that I had travelled from Haridwar hoping to meet one of

their teachers for just a few minutes. The principal listened patiently and then sent someone with a simple message.

“There is a boy here to see you.”

Pragati had absolutely no idea I was anywhere near Mainpuri.

When she stepped into the corridor and saw me standing there, the surprise on her face is something I still remember.

For a few moments, neither of us said very much.

After years of phone calls and one unsuccessful attempt to meet in Agra, we were finally standing face to face again.

The conversation itself was surprisingly ordinary.

I told her about the Rajasthan road trip and how Pradeep and I had decided to come via Mainpuri on our way back. She smiled, still trying to process the unexpected visit.

Around us, children occasionally looked in our direction with curious smiles, wondering who this unfamiliar visitor was talking to their teacher. We both knew we couldn't stand there for very long. Schools are close-knit places, and unexpected visitors naturally attract attention.

There were no grand declarations.

No elaborate plans.

No dramatic promises.

Just the quiet happiness of seeing someone who had become an important part of my life.

Pradeep remained where we had parked the Santro some distance away. He never met Pragati that day. Later he would laugh and tell me he had expected at least an introduction after driving all the way to Mainpuri.

Instead, he spent the morning patiently waiting in the car while I lived one of the most memorable moments of my life.

Before leaving, we simply waved goodbye.

I began walking back towards the road where the Santro was parked.

She remained standing in the school corridor.

Every few steps I turned back.

She was still there.

We waved once more.

Then again.

Eventually the distance between us became too great, and I could no longer make out her face.

As I drove away from Mainpuri, I realised the visit had lasted only a few minutes.

Yet somehow those few minutes made the entire journey across Rajasthan worthwhile.

Looking back today, I think that unexpected visit said more than any conversation could have. It wasn't planned months in advance. There were no gifts, no celebrations and no certainty that I would even find her. It was simply a young engineer driving a few hundred extra kilometres because someone mattered enough to make the effort.

Sometimes the shortest meetings leave the longest memories.

Journey of Faith

One morning, while checking my official mailbox at work, I noticed an email from Anand, a colleague from BHEL's Bangalore unit.

We had first met during our induction training years earlier. Although we were never particularly close, we remained in touch occasionally, perhaps because we were both South Indians who had found ourselves building careers far away from home.

His email was simple.

He was planning a pilgrimage to Amarnath and wanted to know if I, or anyone else from Haridwar, would be interested in joining him.

Until then, I knew almost nothing about Amarnath.

Growing up in Tamil Nadu, our understanding of pilgrimages revolved around places like Tirupati, Rameswaram and Kashi. Haridwar and Rishikesh had become familiar only after I moved north. Amarnath was simply another place I had heard mentioned occasionally.

That was enough.

My answer was an immediate yes.

Initially, two more colleagues from Haridwar planned to join us, but just before Anand finalized the railway reservations, both of them backed out. I still remember sending him an apologetic email asking him to cancel their bookings and reserve a ticket only for me.

His reply arrived the very next morning.

He had already adjusted the reservations and attached a carefully prepared itinerary covering trains, buses, the pilgrimage and sightseeing around Srinagar.

Everything had been planned meticulously.

All I had to do was reach Saharanpur and board his train.

A few days later, I travelled by bus from Haridwar to Saharanpur.

When Anand stepped off the train from Bangalore, it felt like two colleagues were about to become travelling companions.

Neither of us had any idea what lay ahead.

From Saharanpur we continued towards Jammu.

Our original plan was to travel onward by bus to Pahalgam, but thousands of pilgrims had already arrived for the yatra and every bus was overflowing with passengers.

Eventually we found a Tata Sumo willing to take us.

Anand and I quietly negotiated with the driver, offering to pay a little extra if he would let us occupy the front seats.

After all, if we were travelling through Kashmir, we wanted the best view possible.

The driver smiled.

The deal was done.

By evening we approached an Army checkpoint near Anantnag.

Security personnel stopped every vehicle.

The officer informed us that civilian vehicles would not be allowed to proceed any further that night. We were instructed to return to a transit camp a few kilometres behind, where all pilgrims would halt before travelling the next morning under Army escort.

The transit camp turned out to be a large FCI warehouse.

When we reached its entrance, hundreds of pilgrims had already occupied every available corner.

Anand and I looked inside.

Then we quietly looked at each other.

Without saying much, we walked back to the Tata Sumo.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Our sleeping bags were still inside.

We asked the driver whether we could simply sleep in the vehicle instead.

He hesitated.

His only concern was that the Army might inspect vehicles during the night and question why passengers were sleeping inside.

Eventually he agreed.

That Tata Sumo became our hotel for the night.

At dawn the following morning, the convoy assembled.

Armoured military vehicles led the way.

Another brought up the rear.

Between them travelled twenty or thirty vehicles carrying pilgrims from every corner of the country.

Only then did I begin to appreciate how carefully the pilgrimage was being protected.

Once we reached Pahalgam, another short bus ride took us to the actual starting point of the trek.

Like many first-time trekkers, Anand and I made one major mistake.

We carried our backpacks ourselves.

They hadn't seemed particularly heavy while packing them in Haridwar.

On the mountains, every kilogram suddenly felt ten times heavier.

The climb was relentless.

Steep mountain paths stretched ahead for kilometre after kilometre.

After several hours of walking, I was completely exhausted.

I seriously considered hiring a pony for the remainder of the journey.

Anand had other ideas.

“We’ve come this far,” he said. “Let’s finish it on foot.”

Instead of hiring ponies, we found a porter willing to carry our backpacks.

Freed from the weight on our shoulders, the climb suddenly became manageable again.

Over two days, covering more than twenty-five kilometres through the mountains, we slowly made our way towards the cave, stopping at Army-managed transit camps along the route whenever we needed rest.

When we finally reached the base of the cave, we were covered in dust from the long trek.

Before joining the queue for darshan, we decided that we could not enter the shrine without first taking a bath.

Our belongings were left safely in a small shop beside the icy stream flowing near the cave.

As we walked towards the water, something puzzled me.

People were standing in neat queues inside the stream itself.

For a few moments I couldn’t understand why anyone would queue in flowing water.

Then I noticed the reason.

Only a handful of large rocks were exposed above the streambed.

Everywhere else was glacial ice.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

People patiently waited for their turn to stand barefoot on those rocks because stepping directly onto the surrounding ice was almost unbearable.

Gathering all the courage we could, we stepped into the freezing water, somehow managed our bath, changed into fresh clothes and finally began the climb towards the cave.

Inside, I stood quietly before the naturally formed ice lingam.

Only a few weeks earlier, I had known almost nothing about Amarnath.

Now I found myself standing in one of India's most revered pilgrimage sites, surrounded by thousands of devotees who had travelled far greater distances than I had.

It was a feeling that is difficult to describe even today.

The return journey followed the Baltal route before we eventually reached Srinagar.

After the physical demands of the pilgrimage, Srinagar felt wonderfully peaceful.

The weather was pleasant, the city looked beautiful in the summer, and for the first time in several days we could simply slow down.

We stayed in a modest houseboat on one of the quieter water channels near Dal Lake, explored the famous lake itself and visited the Shankaracharya Temple overlooking the city.

Soon it was time to return.

At Jammu our journeys separated.

Anand boarded his train back to Bangalore.

I boarded another train that would take me back to Haridwar.

Life quickly returned to its familiar rhythm.

A few days later, I carried packets of prasad from Amarnath to the office and shared them with my colleagues in ITX.

As I handed one to Sunita Sharma, she smiled and asked where I had been.

When I told her about the pilgrimage, she looked at me with genuine surprise.

“Ravi,” she said, “people of our age only dream of going to Amarnath. You’ve already completed it at such a young age.”

Until that moment, I had never thought of the journey as anything extraordinary.

To me, it had simply been another opportunity to explore a part of India I knew nothing about.

Looking back today, I sometimes wonder whether I would have accepted Anand’s invitation had I fully understood how physically demanding and challenging the pilgrimage would be.

Perhaps not.

Sometimes, not knowing the difficulty ahead gives us the courage to begin.

And occasionally, those unplanned journeys become the ones we treasure the most.

Part IV - Crossroads

Chapter 10 - Goodbye

The Call From Home

By the end of 2005, life had settled into a rhythm that felt almost predictable.

Work at BHEL continued to be engaging. The Quality Through Monitoring project had become part of everyday operations, and the recognition it brought had quietly strengthened my confidence within the organization. I was no longer the young engineer trying to prove himself. I had become someone people trusted with responsibility.

Outside the office, another journey was slowly drawing to a close.

The BITS Pilani master's programme that had occupied my evenings for nearly two years was entering its final phase. What had begun as a casual conversation with Sumit Aggarwal had become one of the most rewarding decisions of my professional life.

Assignments had become routine.

Examinations in Delhi no longer felt intimidating.

The long drives with Bhaskar Joshi, the overnight stays at Sumit sir's mother's apartment and the pressure of open-book examinations had gradually become cherished memories rather than challenges.

Looking back, pursuing a master's degree while working full-time demanded discipline, but it also transformed the way I approached software engineering. I no longer looked at programming as merely writing code. I had begun to appreciate the principles, architecture and discipline behind building good software.

Life outside work had been equally generous.

The past few years had given me friendships that endured, journeys across Rajasthan, an unforgettable pilgrimage to Amarnath and the

quiet reassurance that my relationship with Pragati continued to grow stronger despite the distance between us.

On the surface, everything seemed to be falling into place.

Yet, far away in Chennai, another story was unfolding.

Ever since his bypass surgery in 1994, my father had lived with recurring health issues. Most episodes passed after medication and rest, but towards the end of 2005 the phone calls from home began to change.

My sister would occasionally mention that he had been feeling unusually tired.

My mother would say he had experienced heaviness in his chest again.

The episodes were never dramatic enough to cause immediate panic, yet they were frequent enough to remind us that his health was no longer what it had once been.

Each conversation ended the same way.

“He is better now.”

And life would continue.

Perhaps because we had lived through similar episodes before, none of us imagined that these calls were quietly preparing us for something much bigger.

Around the same time, another thought had begun occupying my mind.

Professionally, I felt I had reached an important milestone.

With nearly six years at BHEL, meaningful software projects behind me and a master’s degree nearing completion, I found myself wondering what the next chapter of my career might look like.

BHEL had given me everything a young engineer could have hoped for.

It had transformed a hesitant graduate into a confident software professional.

It had given me mentors, lifelong friends, opportunities I had never expected and a city that had become my second home.

Leaving was never about dissatisfaction.

It was about growth.

The software industry outside BHEL was changing rapidly. Enterprise applications, internet technologies and global software development were expanding at a pace that fascinated me. I wanted to experience that world while I was still young enough to begin again.

It wasn't a decision I announced to anyone.

It was simply a thought that returned more often with each passing week.

Occasionally, after finishing my work for the day, I found myself browsing job opportunities, reading about multinational software companies and wondering what life outside BHEL might be like.

For the first time since arriving in Haridwar, I could sense that another turning point was approaching.

I didn't know where it would lead.

I certainly didn't know how quickly life would change over the next few months.

I only knew that one chapter of my life was quietly drawing to a close, even as I continued living it one ordinary day at a time.

A Leap Of Faith

By early 2006, the thought that had quietly occupied my mind for months had turned into a decision.

I was ready to move on.

The decision wasn't driven by disappointment or frustration. Quite the opposite. BHEL had given me everything I could have hoped for as a young engineer. It had taught me how to think, how to solve problems and how to earn the trust of people much more experienced than myself.

But software was changing rapidly.

Enterprise applications, web technologies and multinational software companies were redefining the industry. With nearly six years of experience and a master's degree nearing completion, I felt it was the right time to step into that world.

The interviews happened quietly.

Most of my preparation took place after office hours, often without anyone around me realizing that I was exploring new opportunities.

Eventually, I received an offer from a multinational software company in Delhi.

Accepting it was both exciting and unsettling.

For the first time in my career, I was choosing uncertainty over security.

BHEL was not simply another employer.

It was an institution.

People joined BHEL expecting to spend an entire career there. Stability, respect and a predictable future were part of its identity. Walking away from that certainty wasn't a decision many people understood.

GOODBYE

Around the same time, another concern occupied my thoughts.

My father's health had continued to decline.

The episodes of chest discomfort had become more frequent, and in March 2006 I travelled to Chennai to spend a few days with my parents.

Seeing him in person was different from hearing about his health over the phone.

He looked weaker than I remembered.

Yet he remained remarkably calm.

We spoke about ordinary things—my work, life in Haridwar and the completion of my master's degree.

Then I told him about the decision I had made.

I had accepted a job in Delhi.

He listened quietly.

For someone who had spent his working life believing in the security of a stable government career, the decision must have sounded risky. BHEL represented certainty. The private software industry represented something much less predictable.

Yet he never questioned my judgment.

Perhaps he sensed that I had thought it through carefully.

Perhaps he simply trusted me.

Before leaving Chennai, I spoke to him about something else that had become equally important.

I told him about Pragati.

By then she had been part of my life for several years, even though our relationship had remained known only to a handful of people. I

wanted my father to hear about her directly from me rather than through someone else.

He listened with the same quiet attention.

There were very few questions.

No dramatic discussions.

No objections.

Only the reassuring confidence of a father who believed his son would make the right decision.

I shared Pragati's phone number with him before returning north.

Sometime after I left Chennai, he spoke to her over the phone.

When we spoke later, he told me he was happy with my choice.

That simple conversation meant more to me than I realised at the time.

A few weeks later, I submitted my resignation from BHEL.

The news spread quickly across ITX.

Many of my colleagues were genuinely surprised. In those days, leaving BHEL voluntarily was uncommon. It was seen as a place where people built entire careers, enjoying stability and security that few organizations could offer.

More than one person asked me the same question.

"Why would you leave BHEL?"

The answer was never easy to explain.

I wasn't leaving because I was unhappy.

I wasn't running away from anything.

GOODBYE

I simply felt I had reached a stage where I wanted to experience the rapidly changing world of enterprise software beyond the boundaries of a public sector organization. BHEL had given me a strong foundation. I wanted to discover what came next.

My farewell was warm and heartfelt.

As I looked around the familiar faces in ITX, I realised how much the department had shaped me—not only as an engineer but also as a person. The friendships, the mentors and the projects had all become part of who I was.

On 21 April 2006, I joined my new company in Delhi.

The move itself felt surprisingly simple.

I packed a single suitcase with a few clothes, some books and the essentials I would need for the first few weeks. Everything else remained exactly where it was in my quarters at Haridwar.

After all, I wasn't leaving permanently.

The plan was simple. I would settle down in Delhi, return to Haridwar after a few weeks, complete the formalities, pack the rest of my belongings and close that chapter properly.

Early one morning, I loaded the suitcase into my Santro and began the familiar drive from Haridwar to Delhi. It was a journey I had made many times before, but this time it felt different. I wasn't travelling for a weekend, an examination or a road trip.

I was driving towards a new life.

As I left Haridwar behind, I believed I would soon be back.

I had no idea that the farewell I had shared with my colleagues a few days earlier would turn out to be my real goodbye.

The Phone Call

Barely two weeks had passed since I had joined my new company in Delhi when life changed in a way I had never imagined.

On the evening of 8 May 2006, my phone rang.

It was my mother.

Her voice was calm, but I could hear the fear behind it.

The doctors had said my father's condition was extremely critical. They had asked the family to inform close relatives.

It was the first time I had heard those words.

For years, we had lived with my father's recurring health problems. Ever since his bypass surgery in 1994, there had been periods of hospitalization followed by recovery. Every time he became unwell, he somehow fought his way back.

This time felt different.

I didn't know what to think.

Part of me wanted to believe this would be another one of those difficult episodes that he would overcome.

Another part quietly feared that it wouldn't.

My immediate concern was getting to Chennai.

Late evening flights were difficult to find, but by what felt like sheer good fortune, I managed to secure a seat on the first available flight the following morning.

That night, sleep never really came.

My mind wandered endlessly between hope and fear.

Only a few weeks earlier, I had spoken to my father about my new job and about Pragati. He had listened quietly, trusted my decisions and wished me well.

GOODBYE

I kept telling myself that I would see him again in a few hours.

The flight reached Chennai early the next morning.

From the airport, I took a taxi directly to MMM Hospital in Anna Nagar.

Outside the Intensive Care Unit, my mother and sister were waiting.

Neither of them said very much.

There was nothing left to say.

Through the small glass window in the ICU doors, I could see doctors and nurses moving around my father's bed, doing everything they could.

I stood there helplessly, watching from a distance.

I never got the opportunity to speak to him.

About an hour after I arrived, the doctors came out.

My father was gone.

The hours that followed passed almost mechanically.

There were hospital formalities to complete, documents to sign and decisions to make. Someone asked whether we wished to preserve the body in case relatives were arriving from overseas. There was no need.

By afternoon, we began the journey home.

The ambulance carrying my father's body stopped outside our house in Thiruvanniyur.

As neighbours gathered and relatives slowly began arriving, the reality of what had happened finally settled upon me.

Until then, everything had felt unreal.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

Seeing him lying quietly inside the house where we had lived together for so many years broke something within me.

For the first time since receiving my mother's call, I cried without restraint.

The house that had always echoed with his presence had suddenly fallen silent.

Since it was already evening, the cremation was scheduled for the following day.

An ice box was arranged, relatives continued to arrive through the night and none of us slept very much.

My mother spoke very little.

My sister sat quietly beside her.

Grief had left all of us searching for words that simply did not exist.

The next morning, after the final rites at the electric crematorium in Besant Nagar and the rituals on the shores of the Thiruvannamiyur beach, we returned home.

The house was quieter than it had ever been.

Over the next few days, relatives gradually returned to their own lives.

Each departure made the silence inside the house even more noticeable.

Looking back today, I realise my father had spent his entire life preparing us for this day, even if none of us recognised it then.

He was a strict father, sometimes demanding, often uncompromising, but everything he did came from a simple belief.

Education was the one thing that could remain with us long after he was gone.

GOODBYE

He wanted his children to be able to stand on their own feet, independent of anyone else's support.

Only after losing him did I fully understand what he had been trying to teach us all those years.

As I looked at my mother and my sister, I knew I could not leave them behind in a house that had suddenly become filled with memories and emptiness.

Some relatives advised us not to leave Chennai for several months.

Tradition, they said, expected the family to remain in the house after a death.

I understood their intentions.

But at that moment, rituals seemed far less important than the people sitting beside me.

My mother and sister did not need tradition.

They needed family.

A few days later, we left Chennai together and reached Delhi.

Ashes to the Ganges

We left Delhi for Haridwar.

We started before sunrise.

I had always preferred beginning long drives early. The roads were quieter, the weather cooler, and reaching before the afternoon somehow made every journey feel easier.

This drive was different.

I was behind the wheel.

My sister sat beside me.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

My mother sat in the back seat holding an earthen pot wrapped carefully in a white cotton cloth.

It contained my father's ashes.

Before leaving, we had been told that the pot should never be placed on the ground. Throughout the journey, one of us always held it in our hands.

I remember very little about the drive itself.

I don't remember what we spoke about.

Perhaps we hardly spoke at all.

By the time we reached Haridwar, it was already late afternoon.

Before leaving Delhi, I had spoken to Gita Madam. She had kindly arranged for a priest to meet us at Har Ki Pauri.

We drove straight to the ghat.

The priest was already waiting for us.

He began the rituals by asking the customary questions—my father's name, our family name and our gotra. Then, with quiet familiarity, he guided us through each step.

The ghat opposite the clock tower was moderately crowded.

Around us, several other families had gathered for the same reason.

Each stood with an earthen pot wrapped in white cloth, preparing to bid farewell to someone they loved.

It was a reminder that we were not the first family to stand there, and we would certainly not be the last.

When the time came, I stepped into the Ganges and immersed my father's ashes.

GOODBYE

The river carried them away, just as it had carried countless others before.

Somehow, I felt this was what my father would have wanted.

The rituals ended with an act of charity.

The priest directed us to a small restaurant near the ghat. We paid for meals to be served to poor people waiting nearby. I no longer remember how many people were fed, only that it was part of the final rites.

Afterwards, we drove to the BHEL township.

My mother met a few of our neighbour aunties, who had heard about my father's passing. They offered their condolences and spent some time talking to her.

We also visited a few colleagues before beginning our journey back to Delhi.

The visit was brief.

Haridwar no longer felt like a place I had come home to.

It had quietly become a place I had returned to.

A few weeks later, the last traces of my life there also began their journey.

One of my BHEL colleagues in haridwar had been transferred to Delhi. Along with his own household goods, my colleagues and juniors packed the belongings I had left behind and loaded them onto the same truck bound for Delhi.

By then, we had already brought back some of the smaller things ourselves during our visit.

The truck carried the rest.

THE WHITE ENVELOPE

When I had first arrived in Haridwar six years earlier, everything I owned had fit into a single suitcase and a green bedroll.

Now it took an entire truck to bring that chapter of my life to Delhi.

I had left Haridwar believing I would return in a few weeks.

I never did.

Chapter 11 - Beginning Again

New Beginnings

By the time we returned from Haridwar, life had already begun demanding our attention again.

I had recently moved out of the company accommodation into a rented apartment on the second floor of a house in Sector 19, Noida. It was close enough to my office in Sector 2 that the daily commute was easy, and I was still settling into both my new home and my new job.

Soon after my father had passed away, I had informed Pragati about what had happened. When they knew we were back in Delhi she and her father travelled from Mainpuri to visit us in Noida and offer their condolences.

It was the first time our families had met.

There were no discussions about marriage or future plans.

That would have been inappropriate at a time like this.

They had come for only one reason—to share our grief.

The visit was simple and brief.

My mother and sister spoke with them while we all sat together in the living room. There was no formality beyond what the occasion demanded. Looking back, I often think about that afternoon because it was the first time Pragati's father saw my family and the life we had built. Ours was a simple middle-class family with modest means, and there was nothing we tried to hide or present differently.

After spending some time with us, they quietly returned to Mainpuri.

The apartment was small but comfortable. We slowly settled into a routine that felt very different from the past few weeks. There were groceries to buy, meals to prepare, relatives to call and countless small

things that needed attention. Grief had not disappeared, but everyday life had quietly found its place alongside it.

I was still getting used to my new workplace. Everything around me was unfamiliar—new colleagues, new projects and a different way of working. During the day, work kept me occupied. In the evenings, I returned to an apartment that no longer felt empty.

A few days later, my mother and sister also left for Chennai.

The apartment became quiet once again.

For the second time in a matter of weeks, I found myself starting over.

This time, however, there was no uncertainty about what needed to be done.

I immersed myself in my new job, gradually settled into life in Noida and began looking ahead. The difficult weeks following my father's passing had come to an end, and although his absence would always remain, life had gently begun moving forward once again.

The Unexpected Call

By November 2006, life had gradually settled into a comfortable routine again.

I had become familiar with my new job, my apartment in Sector 19 had begun to feel like home, and the daily drive to the office in Sector 2 had become just another part of everyday life. My mother and sister had returned to Chennai after spending a few weeks with me, and I had slowly settled into the rhythm of my new life in Noida.

One afternoon, while I was in my office, my phone rang.

It was Pragati.

There was an excitement in her voice that immediately caught my attention.

“I’m in Chennai,” she said.

For a moment, I was completely surprised.

Before I could ask anything, she continued.

“My father and Chacha are with me. They’ve come to meet your mother.”

They had already travelled to Noida a few months earlier to offer their condolences after my father’s passing. I hadn’t expected them to make another trip so soon, especially to Chennai.

Then she said something that completely changed the conversation.

“If you really want this marriage to happen, you should come to Chennai immediately.”

There was nothing more to think about.

I informed my office, made the necessary travel arrangements and left for Chennai at the earliest opportunity.

When I reached Chennai, I went directly to the hotel where Pragati, her father and her Chacha were staying.

The purpose of this visit was very different from the one a few months earlier.

This time, both families had come together to discuss our marriage.

My father was no longer with us, and Pragati’s mother had passed away when she was still in school. In many ways, both families understood each other’s circumstances without needing elaborate conversations.

They met my mother again, visited our home in Thiruvananthapuram and spent time talking with the family. The discussions were simple, practical and filled with goodwill. There were no demands, no expectations and no lengthy negotiations.

Somewhere during those conversations, a quiet decision was made.

There was no reason to wait any longer.

Our engagement would take place within the next few days.

I had come to Chennai expecting to spend a day or two before returning to Noida.

Instead, I stayed back.

Suddenly there were dates to finalize, relatives to inform and preparations to begin.

For almost six years, marriage had remained somewhere in the distant future.

Now, everything seemed to be happening at once.

The Engagement

Once both families agreed to move forward, life suddenly became very busy.

I stayed back in Chennai instead of returning to Noida. There was simply too much to be done in a short time. Every day seemed to begin with another errand, another phone call or another decision. After waiting for so many years without any certainty about marriage, it felt strange to see everything coming together so quickly.

Most of the arrangements happened naturally.

There was no single person coordinating everything. I found myself handling many of the tasks, while both families worked together to complete whatever remained. Looking back now, I remember how simple the entire process was. There were no complicated discussions or disagreements. Everyone seemed to share the same objective—to prepare for the engagement and begin planning the wedding.

Over the next few days, we visited shops across Chennai.

There were silk sarees to purchase, rings to choose and countless small things that every traditional Tamil engagement required. Both families went shopping together, making decisions as we went along. I no longer remember the jewellery shop where we bought our rings, but I remember choosing a simple pair of gold rings that felt just right for us.

One of the happiest surprises during those days was seeing my close friend Pradeep.

He happened to be in India at the time, and I asked him to come to Chennai if he could. He had been part of our story from the early days and was genuinely happy to see everything finally taking shape.

The engagement was held on 12 November 2006 in a small hall at a hotel near our home in Thiruvannamiyur.

It was not a large gathering. The hall could probably accommodate no more than fifty people, and almost everyone present was either a close relative or a family friend.

I still remember seeing Pragati that evening.

She was wearing a light blue silk saree, her hair beautifully arranged with jasmine flowers woven into it. Until then, all our conversations had revolved around work, travel and trying to find time to meet each other. Seeing her dressed for our engagement made the occasion suddenly feel real.

The ceremony followed traditional Tamil customs.

Our families exchanged trays containing silk sarees, fruits, flowers and other ceremonial gifts. We exchanged rings in the presence of our relatives, and the elders blessed us as the rituals came to an end.

One tradition has stayed with me all these years.

An engagement letter was handwritten in green ink by one of my maternal uncles. It recorded the names of both families and formally stated their agreement that our marriage would take place on an auspicious date. Pragati's father signed the letter, and with that simple document, our engagement became official.

Outside, it had rained earlier in the day.

The November showers had left the roads around Thiruvannamiyur wet, with water collected along the sides of the streets. Like many evenings during the northeast monsoon in Chennai, the weather quietly became part of the memories we carried from that day.

The celebrations were simple.

There were photographs, conversations with relatives and the quiet satisfaction of seeing two families come together with warmth and goodwill. Many of our relatives were surprised by how quickly everything had happened, although my mother had already shared enough of our story for them to understand why the engagement had been arranged without much delay.

The very next day, life began moving again.

Pragati, her father, her uncle and I flew back to Delhi together. From there, they continued to Roorkee to begin planning the wedding from their side, while I returned to my office and settled back into work.

The engagement had lasted only an evening.

The journey towards our marriage had just begun.

A Difficult Choice

Life had barely settled down after our engagement when another unexpected turn arrived.

I had returned to Noida after the engagement while Pragati, her father and her uncle continued to Roorkee to begin making preparations for the wedding from their side. I settled back into work, while my mother and relatives remained busy in Chennai making plans for the wedding. Around the same time, I had also taken up another responsibility. We had decided to build an additional floor above our house in Thiruvanmiyur, and I had instructed the contractor that the work had to be completed before the wedding, irrespective of what it cost. Looking back now, I sometimes wonder how I managed to juggle so many things at the same time.

Just when life seemed busy enough, my manager called me into his office.

For several months, I had been working with a client in the United States. Almost all our interactions had happened over conference calls, and the client had finally expressed a desire to meet the team they had been speaking to for so long. I was asked to travel to the United States before the end of the year.

Everything happened in a hurry.

My B1 visa was processed just before the Christmas holidays, travel arrangements were made almost overnight, and before I had enough time to absorb the news, my tickets had already been booked. It was my first opportunity to travel to the United States, and professionally it was an important milestone.

When I shared the news with Pragati, her reaction was completely different from what I had expected.

She did not want me to travel.

Even today, I cannot say with certainty what worried her so much. Perhaps everything had happened too quickly over the previous few months. Perhaps she was anxious about the wedding. Perhaps there were reasons that neither of us knew how to express at the time. I

have often thought about those conversations, but I still do not know the answer.

I tried to find a middle path.

I suggested that if travelling abroad was the concern, I would speak to my office and see whether it would be possible for her to accompany me. That idea was rejected immediately. I even gave her my manager's phone number and suggested that she speak to him directly if it would help.

To my surprise, she did exactly that.

She called my manager and told him that I should either get married first or travel to the United States, but not both.

That conversation deeply disturbed me.

Until then, I had looked at the situation as a problem that both of us would solve together. After that phone call, something changed within me. I felt that a professional commitment I had already accepted had unnecessarily become a matter between my office and my personal life.

The discussions between us became arguments.

The arguments became silence.

At one point, I made up my mind that the marriage would not happen.

It was not a decision made in anger alone. I genuinely believed that if we could not find common ground on something as important as this, it was better to step away before the wedding rather than after it.

What made the situation even stranger was that nobody else knew.

Our families continued making wedding preparations with great enthusiasm, completely unaware that the two people who were supposed to get married had almost decided to go their separate ways.

BEGINNING AGAIN

On 31 December 2006, I boarded a British Airways flight to New York.

The journey itself did not go as planned.

My connecting flight from London Heathrow was delayed, and I missed the onward connection to Newark. With most of my belongings checked in and very little in my cabin baggage, I suddenly found myself stranded at Heathrow for several hours waiting for the next available flight.

I was equally worried about the people waiting for me in the United States.

This was my first visit to the country, and I had no easy way of informing the client or the colleagues who had come to receive me. I could only hope that someone, somewhere, knew what had happened.

When I finally landed at Newark several hours later, the first thing I looked for was a familiar face.

To my immense relief, someone was still standing there holding a placard with my name.

Only later did I learn that my company had contacted British Airways, tracked the delay and informed the team in the United States about my revised arrival time.

I don't think I have ever been happier to see a stranger waiting for me.

The next three weeks were spent in Norwalk, Connecticut.

The work itself was fairly routine. We met the client, attended meetings, discussed the project and continued with the same work we had already been doing from India. Professionally, it was an important experience, but personally my thoughts were often somewhere else.

Pragati and I spoke only a handful of times during those weeks.

Gradually, the conversations became calmer.

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The anger that had clouded our earlier discussions slowly gave way to understanding, and somewhere during those weeks we quietly decided that the marriage would go ahead after all.

Neither of our families knew anything about what had happened.

While they remained busy making arrangements for the wedding, we had resolved the biggest uncertainty ourselves.

I returned to Delhi on 26 January 2007.

There were barely two weeks left before the wedding, and there was still a great deal to do.

This time, there were no more doubts.

Only preparations.

Part V - Two Families

Chapter 12 - Becoming Family

The Wedding Journey

I returned from the United States on 26 January 2007 with barely two weeks left before the wedding. The previous month had passed in a blur of client meetings, airports and uncertainty, and it was only after landing in Delhi that I truly realized how much still remained to be done. Wedding preparations that had continued in my absence now demanded my complete attention, while the construction of the additional floor at our house in Thiruvannamiyur was also progressing against an ambitious deadline. Life had become a careful balancing act between office work, construction updates, travel plans and the countless small arrangements that accompany an Indian wedding.

A few days later, my mother arrived in Delhi to help with the final preparations. Her journey itself produced one of those memories that only becomes amusing with time. At the baggage carousel, she accidentally picked up a blue duffle bag that looked identical to ours and returned home without realizing the mistake. It was only after reaching the apartment that we discovered the lock was different and the bag was not ours. We never attempted to open it. Fortunately, the young woman who had unknowingly taken our bag discovered several wedding invitation cards inside, each carrying my name and mobile number. She contacted me, drove all the way to Noida, and we exchanged the bags with much laughter. It was a small incident, but somehow it became part of the memories surrounding our wedding.

With my mother now in Delhi, the pace of preparations quickened. Most of our relatives from Chennai would be travelling together by train directly to Agra, while my mother and I planned to drive there a little earlier so that we could receive everyone when they arrived. Since I was already familiar with the route, I also arranged two SUVs from Delhi that would travel empty to Agra. Their sole purpose was

to receive our relatives at the railway station, take them to the hotel and remain available throughout the wedding celebrations. Looking back, I sometimes wonder how all these arrangements came together without mobile apps, online bookings or instant messaging. Somehow they simply did.

My relatives had a journey of their own.

Except for my mother and sister, almost none of them had ever travelled to North India before. The wedding had become more than a family celebration; it was also an opportunity to visit places they had only heard about. Many of them were excited about seeing Agra and later visiting the Taj Mahal, something they still speak about whenever we meet even today. I was not with them during that train journey, as I had already reached Delhi after returning from America, but I often imagine the conversations that must have filled their compartment. Having experienced my own first journey to North India seven years earlier, I could almost picture their excitement as the train moved steadily north.

There was another thought that often makes me smile even today.

Except for my mother and sister, none of my relatives could speak Hindi. On the other hand, most of Pragati's relatives came from Agra and the surrounding towns, and very few of them knew Tamil. I still have no idea how those two families managed to communicate over the next few days. Somehow they did. Smiles, gestures, translated sentences and the shared excitement of a wedding probably succeeded where language could not.

My mother and I left for Agra before the train carrying our relatives arrived. The drive was familiar by then, and by the time we reached the hotel, the rooms reserved for our side of the family were ready. We kept our luggage, completed a few last-minute formalities and waited for the arrival of the train. One by one, our relatives began to arrive, tired from the long journey but visibly excited to be there.

Watching them step into Agra, wrapped in sweaters that many of them had probably never imagined they would need in February, reminded me of my own arrival in Haridwar years earlier, when I too had underestimated what a North Indian winter could feel like.

Pragati and her family were staying at another nearby hotel along with their relatives, most of whom belonged to Agra and the neighbouring towns. Naturally, many of them were curious about the South Indian engineer whom Pragati had chosen to marry. I later learnt that quite a few expected me to struggle with Hindi. Their surprise disappeared within the first few minutes of conversation, and before long, I was simply another member of the family. Looking back, I think that small discovery helped both families feel more comfortable with each other even before the wedding ceremonies began.

As evening approached, the hotels slowly came alive with the familiar sights and sounds that accompany every Indian wedding. Relatives who had not met for years renewed old conversations, children explored every corridor they could find, elders compared travel experiences, and someone was always searching for another cup of tea. After months of uncertainty, arguments, travel and hurried preparations, it was comforting to see everyone gathered under one roof, waiting for the celebrations to begin.

The next morning, we would become one family.

Two Weddings

The wedding day began long before sunrise.

The muhurtham had been fixed for around six o'clock in the morning, which meant that the entire family had to wake up much earlier and get ready before dawn. For our relatives who had travelled from Chennai, this itself became an unforgettable experience. Most of them

had never visited North India before, and very few had ever experienced a winter morning like the one that greeted us in Agra. Standing in long queues outside the hotel rooms waiting for their turn to use the bathrooms, searching for hot water from geysers that were almost unknown in our homes back then, and wrapping themselves in sweaters over their traditional clothes, they slowly discovered that a February morning in North India was very different from anything they had known in Chennai.

By the time I wore my white veshti and shirt and reached the marriage hall, the first signs of daylight were only beginning to appear outside. Inside, however, the hall was already alive with activity. Priests were arranging the ceremonial items, relatives greeted one another with sleepy smiles, photographers moved quietly from one corner to another, and somewhere in the middle of all the activity my mother moved from one responsibility to the next, making sure that everything was in place.

We had brought an Iyer from Delhi to conduct the Tamil wedding according to our family traditions. It turned out that even priests are not immune to regional differences. More than once during the ceremonies, one of our elderly relatives gently corrected him about the sequence of a ritual or the way a particular custom was performed in our family. Watching those small discussions unfold in the middle of the wedding brought unexpected smiles to many faces and reminded me that traditions, much like families, often have their own local variations.

There was one absence that everyone quietly understood.

My father had passed away less than a year earlier, and many of the traditional responsibilities that would normally have belonged to him were performed by my mother's sister and her husband. They stepped forward without hesitation, allowing every ritual to continue with

dignity and warmth. Nothing more needed to be said. Their presence spoke for itself.

As the ceremonies continued, I gradually stopped noticing the individual rituals and simply allowed myself to be carried along by them. The familiar sequence of blessings, prayers and customs that I had watched at countless weddings over the years now unfolded around me as though I had become a participant almost by accident.

Pragati looked radiant in the maroon silk saree we had chosen together only a few weeks earlier in Chennai. When she took her place beside me, the hurried shopping trips, the engagement, my unexpected trip to America and all the uncertainty of the previous months suddenly felt very far away.

The ceremonies continued one after another.

There was the Kanyadaan, the exchange of garlands, the playful search for rings inside a brass vessel filled with water, and finally the most important moment of the morning.

My mother had chosen the thali from GRT Jewellers in Chennai, carefully following the traditions that had been followed in our family for generations. Suspended on a simple yellow thread, it represented far more than a piece of jewellery.

When the priest signalled the auspicious moment, I tied the first knot.

As tradition required, my cousin sister tied the remaining knots while the hall echoed with the sounds of nadaswaram, blessings and applause. Somewhere among the many photographs taken that morning, there is still one that captures that exact moment. Even today, it remains my favourite photograph from our wedding.

People often describe the moment of marriage as life-changing, but my own memory is much quieter.

I do not remember feeling overwhelmed by emotion or suddenly realizing that life had changed forever. If anything, I remember feeling strangely calm, almost as though everything had happened so quickly over the previous few months that my mind had not yet caught up with reality. After six years of waiting, wondering and hoping, the moment had finally arrived, and all I could really do was absorb it one ritual at a time.

One of the things I enjoyed most that morning was watching the reactions of Pragati's relatives. For many of them, this was their first opportunity to witness a traditional Tamil wedding in such detail. The unfamiliar Sanskrit chants, the yellow-thread thali, the sequence of rituals and the customs that had been part of our family for generations were all completely new to them. They watched with genuine curiosity, occasionally asking quiet questions and trying to understand the meaning behind each ceremony.

Once the Tamil wedding concluded, everyone took a short break for breakfast before preparing for the second ceremony.

By afternoon, the atmosphere had changed completely.

The veshti gave way to a sherwani, Pragati changed into another saree, and the North Indian wedding began. Now it was our relatives who became the curious observers, watching another beautiful set of traditions unfold before their eyes. If the morning had belonged to my family, the afternoon belonged to hers.

The rituals were different, but the emotions were the same.

We walked the sacred rounds around the fire, sindoor was applied, blessings were exchanged and relatives from both sides gradually stopped thinking in terms of "their" family and "our" family.

Not every moment was solemn.

Like every North Indian wedding, there were playful traditions as well. At one point, Pragati's sisters spirited away my shoes and demanded money before agreeing to return them. After a good deal of bargaining and laughter, I finally surrendered and paid ₹5,000 to get them back. Looking back now, I suspect they had planned the entire operation long before I realized what was happening.

Among the many people who came forward to bless us that day was one person I noticed with particular gratitude.

A close friend of my late father had travelled to attend the wedding. During my engineering years, he had quietly helped my father at a time when our family needed support the most. Seeing him place his hand on my head and bless us brought back memories of those difficult years. Some relationships never demand recognition; they simply remain part of one's life with quiet dignity.

By evening, the ceremonies had finally come to an end.

The photographers continued asking for one more picture, children who had spent the entire day running around the hall were beginning to tire, and relatives from both sides had now settled into easy conversations despite the fact that many of them shared neither a common language nor a common culture. Looking around the hall, I could not help smiling. Only a few months earlier, I had been wondering whether this wedding would happen at all. Now two families from opposite ends of the country stood together as though they had known one another for years.

Somewhere during that long winter day in Agra, without any speeches or grand declarations, two families had quietly become one.

Coming Home

By the time the wedding ceremonies concluded, it felt as though an entire lifetime had been compressed into a single day. The halls that

had been filled with priests, photographers, relatives and endless conversations slowly began to empty as everyone returned to their rooms, carrying with them photographs, memories and stories that would be retold for many years.

According to custom, Pragati and I were expected to leave Agra soon after the wedding while the rest of the family stayed behind for another day. We had originally planned to drive back immediately, but after a little thought we decided to do something different. There would be nobody at home in Noida to welcome us if we reached before everyone else. Instead, we checked into another hotel and spent a quiet night in Agra, allowing the excitement of the previous day to settle before beginning the next chapter of our lives.

It was probably the first quiet conversation we had shared in many weeks.

The previous months had been consumed by my father's passing, changing jobs, moving to Delhi, our engagement, my unexpected trip to the United States and the whirlwind of wedding preparations. For the first time in a long while, there was nowhere we needed to rush and nothing we needed to organize. The wedding was behind us. The future, for once, could wait until the next morning.

By the time we drove back to Noida, our relatives had already reached our apartment in Sector 19.

The house that had seemed so spacious only a few weeks earlier was now overflowing with people, luggage, laughter and conversations happening in more than one language. As we entered the apartment together, Pragati was welcomed with the traditional ceremonies that mark the arrival of a new bride. An aarthi was performed at the entrance, and she gently nudged the small vessel of rice before stepping into her new home. These were simple rituals, but they quietly marked the beginning of a new phase in both our lives.

For the next few days, our home remained full.

Some of our relatives travelled to Delhi to visit places they had only seen in photographs, returning with cameras full of pictures and stories that would become family favourites. Even today, whenever we meet at weddings or family gatherings, someone invariably recalls that journey to Agra and the excitement of seeing North India for the first time. What had begun as our wedding had also become an unforgettable family holiday for many of them.

One memory from those days still makes me smile.

Except for my mother and sister, almost none of my relatives spoke Hindi. Most of Pragati's relatives, on the other hand, spoke little or no Tamil. Looking back now, I still cannot explain how those two families managed to communicate so effortlessly over several days. They somehow found ways to laugh together, share meals, exchange blessings and pose for photographs, proving once again that warmth often succeeds where language cannot.

Gradually, the house began to grow quieter. The days passed quickly, and before long it was time for our relatives to begin their journey back to Chennai. Just as they had travelled together to Agra a few days earlier, they now gathered once again with their luggage, ready to board the train from New Delhi Railway Station for the long journey home. The excitement that had filled the apartment slowly gave way to a series of farewells, promises to meet again and discussions about photographs, the Taj Mahal and everything they had experienced during those memorable few days in North India. Suitcases that had arrived only days earlier disappeared one by one. Farewells were exchanged, promises were made to visit again, and the apartment slowly returned to the peaceful home it had been before the wedding.

My mother and sister stayed with us for another week before returning to Chennai.

Watching them leave was a different experience from all the farewells that had come before. During the previous year we had stood together through some of the most difficult moments our family had ever faced. We had lost my father, moved across cities, arranged a wedding and welcomed a new member into the family. As I watched them leave for Chennai, I felt grateful for the quiet strength with which my mother had carried us through that difficult year.

A few weeks later, Pragati and I travelled to Chennai for our wedding reception. Many of our relatives and family friends who had been unable to make the long journey to Agra came there to bless us. Unlike the wedding, there were no elaborate rituals or tightly planned schedules. It was a relaxed evening spent meeting people who had watched me grow up and who had known our family for many years. They had heard about the wedding in Agra, seen a few photographs and were happy to finally meet Pragati in person.

As I looked around the reception hall that evening, I realized how naturally the two worlds that had shaped my life had come together. My relatives from Chennai spoke warmly about the wedding in Agra. Pragati's family shared stories from the ceremonies. Somewhere between those conversations, the distinctions between north and south, Tamil and Hindi, my family and hers had quietly faded away.

When the reception ended and the last of our relatives returned home, life slowly settled into its own rhythm once again.

There were office meetings waiting in Noida, a new apartment that was gradually becoming our home, and countless ordinary days that lay ahead. Looking back now, I realize that those ordinary days were perhaps the greatest gift of all. After years of uncertainty, change and constant movement, life had finally become wonderfully ordinary.

Seven years earlier, I had boarded the Tamil Nadu Express carrying a white envelope that would change the direction of my life. I could not have imagined the friendships I would build, the places I would

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discover, the lessons I would learn, the people I would lose or the family I would one day find.

As Pragati and I began our journey together, I did not know what the years ahead would bring.

Just as I had not known then.

And perhaps that was exactly how every worthwhile journey was meant to begin.

Epilogue

The envelope is still with me.

It remains quietly tucked inside the same leather bag where I first placed it more than twenty-five years ago.

Some things are worth keeping.

Not because of what they are...

But because of what they come to mean.

About the Author

V.T.R. Ravi Kumar is a software architect, engineer, photographer, traveler and lifelong student of technology. Over a career spanning more than twenty-five years, he has worked across enterprise software, cloud computing, distributed systems, artificial intelligence and digital transformation, helping organizations build technology at scale while continually adapting to an ever-changing industry.

Outside work, he finds joy in photography, long rides on his Royal Enfield, travel, gardening and creating technology projects that blend engineering with everyday life. He is also the creator of VTR Press, an independent publishing platform born from his desire to write and publish books with the same care and craftsmanship that he brought to building software throughout his career.

Project Memoir is his first personal memoir. More than a chronology of events, it is an attempt to preserve memories, honor the people who shaped his life, and leave behind an honest account of an ordinary life lived through extraordinary changes in India and the technology industry.

Ravi lives in Chennai with his wife, Pragati, where he continues to write, build software, explore new technologies and pursue a lifelong curiosity about how stories and engineering can together create something meaningful.

Thank you for reading my story.

If these pages reminded you of your own journey, then this memoir has accomplished its purpose.

— V.T.R. Ravi Kumar

Connect with the author X: @vtrrk

In January 2000, a young engineering graduate leaves Chennai with a suitcase, a train ticket, and an appointment letter that will take him farther from home than he has ever been.

What begins as the first step of a career gradually becomes the journey of a lifetime.

Across seven formative years, Ravi discovers far more than a profession. Through unfamiliar cities, enduring friendships, moments of uncertainty, personal loss, and the quiet joy of finding love, he learns that growing up rarely happens all at once. More often, it unfolds through the ordinary moments we only learn to appreciate years later.

Set against the backdrop of India at the turn of the millennium, *The White Envelope* is a memoir about leaving home, discovering where we belong, and the memories we carry long after the journey has ended.

Because sometimes the smallest things we choose to keep become the ones that preserve our greatest stories.

—

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